

A GRIMOIRE OF THE OLD RELIGIONS · VOL. I

The Old Norse Grimoire

A window to the old world, gods,
oath & craft

DEDICATION

For Huginn and Muninn.
While they return to Óðinn each night, may they also return to us as well.

Contents

1. Welcome: Working with the Old Ways · 4–6

2. The Poems: what the sources are · 7–12

3. Threshold: Who Were the Old Norse · 13–18

4. Nine Realms: The Gods and Their Kingdoms · 19–28

5. Rǫgn: Gods & Ruling Powers · 29–51

6. Völva & Seiðr: seeress and fate-work · 52–55

7. Hamingja: your luck · 56–59

8. Vitki: rune-reader · 60–61

9. Elves & Dwarfs: neighbors and smiths · 62–72

10. Norse Wheel of the Year: Winter Nights to Midsummer · 73–93

11. Plants & Trees: herbs and ash · 94–112

12. Liminal Places: wells that remember · 113–120

13. Runes: stones with staves · 121–123

14. Staves: use them honestly · 124–129

15. Galdr: Charms: words in old books · 130–140

16. Ancestors: mound-neighbors · 141–146

17. Oath: go on reading · 147–150

Welcome

Working with the Old Ways

Working with the Old Ways

Rest your tired bones and troubled mind. This book shares the old Norse ways, which were about keeping good company with the living, the dead, and the land. It is meant to bring you comfort and a sense of connection with your ancestors. If parts of it do not fit your life or beliefs, leave them behind and keep what helps. I have tried to present these old ways as accurately as the sources allow, and I mark each claim with where it comes from. Use the lines on each page to write, reflect, and build your own practice in whatever way works best for you.

This book covers medicinal plants, but it does not replace a doctor. Never eat, drink, or apply any plant from these pages based on this book alone. If you forage, go with an experienced guide, check each plant against at least three trusted sources, and take only what you need, leaving most of it behind. For medicinal herbs, I buy from Mountain Rose Herbs: https://mountainroseherbs.com/

Where this comes from. Every lore page ends with a short note that says where its ideas come from: a poem, a saga, a stone, a custom, or this book. If a source is late, or scholars disagree, the note says so. Anything described as modern or rebuilt was written for your home and is not an old practice. The main sources are the Poetic Edda, Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda, the medieval rune poems, and the sagas listed in Resources.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What season is it today, outside your actual window? Name three signs.*

How to say the names

Old Norse names look hard, but a few rules cover most of them. The letter Þ (þ) sounds like "th" in thin. The letter Ð (ð) sounds like "th" in this. An accent mark over a vowel means hold it a little longer. The letter ö sounds like the "u" in fur, and j sounds like English "y." The final -r on names like Þórr, Baldr, and Freyr is just a grammar ending, and English often drops it.

Óðinn OH-thin
Þórr THORR
Frigg FRIG
Freyr FRAYR
Freyja FRAY-yah
Týr TEER
Loki LOH-kee
Baldr BAHL-dur
Heimdallr HAIM-dahl-ur
Skaði SKAH-thee
Jörmungandr YOR-mun-gahn-dur
Fenrir FEN-rir
Yggdrasill IG-drah-sil
Ragnarök RAHG-nah-rok
Æsir AY-seer
Vanir VAH-neer

These are English-friendly approximations, not a perfect copy of how the Old Norse spoke. Say them aloud once. The names sound better when you hear them.

Where this comes from: Standard Old Norse pronunciation guides, simplified for English readers.

The Poems

What the old sources are

The Poems Behind This Book

This book leans on a handful of old texts, and you will meet their names on almost every page. Here is what they are. The Poetic Edda is a collection of about thirty poems about gods and heroes. Most of them survive in one Icelandic manuscript, the Codex Regius, copied around 1270. Their poets are unknown. The poems were probably composed between about 900 and 1200 and kept by memory first, so their dates are best guesses.

The Prose Edda was written by Snorri Sturluson, an Icelandic chieftain and poet, around 1220. He wrote it as a handbook for young poets, retelling the myths in plain prose so they could follow the old verse. Snorri was a Christian writing two centuries after Iceland converted, so his version is useful, tidy, and late. Where he and the poems disagree, this book says so.

Two more kinds of text appear here. Icelandic sagas are prose stories about families and kings, written down in the 1200s and later. The medieval rune poems are short verses, one for each rune. The next pages give a short guide to the poems you will meet most often. You do not need to read them first. Come back to this guide whenever a title puzzles you.

Where this comes from: The Codex Regius dates to about 1270 and Snorri's Prose Edda to about 1220. The dates of the individual poems are debated.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Which poem do you most want to understand? Write its name and why you chose it. Give it two dated lines.

Poems of wisdom and the world

Völuspá (Voluspa), "the seeress's prophecy." A seeress tells Óðinn the story of the world, from its making to its ending at Ragnarök and its return.

Hávamál (Havamal), "Sayings of the High One." Óðinn's advice on guests, friends, and keeping your wits. It also tells how he won the runes and lists the charms he knows.

Grímnismál (Grimnismal), "Grímnir's sayings." Óðinn, in disguise and held captive, names the halls of the gods and the shape of the worlds.

Vafþrúðnismál (Vafthrudnismal), "Vafþrúðnir's sayings." Óðinn and a wise giant test each other with questions about the world, its making, and its end.

Sigrdrífumál (Sigrdrifumal), "Sigrdrífa's sayings." A valkyrie wakes and teaches the hero Sigurðr runes and counsel.

The rune poems. Three medieval poems, Norwegian, Icelandic, and Anglo-Saxon, give each rune a short verse of its own.

Where this comes from: These poems are in the Poetic Edda and the medieval rune poems.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which of these poems offers advice you could use this week? Name it and one line of the advice. Give it two dated lines.*

Poems of the gods

Lokasenna, "Loki's quarrel." Loki crashes a feast and insults the gods. The next page tells it in full.

Þrymskviða (Thrymskvida), "the lay of Þrymr." A giant steals Þórr's hammer, and Þórr gets it back dressed as a bride.

Skírnismál (Skirnismal), "Skírnir's sayings." Freyr's servant Skírnir goes to win the giant maid Gerðr for him.

Hymiskviða (Hymiskvida), "the lay of Hymir." Þórr visits the giant Hymir for a great kettle and goes fishing for the world serpent.

Alvíssmál (Alvissmal), "Alvíss's sayings." Þórr keeps a dwarf answering riddles until the sun comes up.

Hárbarðsljóð (Harbardsljod), "Hárbarðr's song." Þórr trades insults with a ferryman, usually understood to be Óðinn in disguise.

Völundarkviða (Volundarkvida), "the lay of Völundr." A captive smith takes revenge on a king.

Hyndluljóð (Hyndluljod), "the song of Hyndla." Freyja questions a giantess about family lines.

Where this comes from: These poems are in the Poetic Edda.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which of these tales would you read aloud to someone you love? Name it and who you would read it to. Give it two dated lines.*

The Lokasenna: Loki's quarrel

The Lokasenna is a flyting, a contest of insults, and it is the poem this book cites most when it speaks of Loki. The sea-giant Ægir (Aegir) brews ale for the gods and holds a feast. Þórr is away in the east. Loki has already killed one of Ægir's servants and been chased out, but he walks back in and demands a seat.

One by one he insults the gods, accusing them of cowardice and unfaithfulness. They answer him, and he has a cruel reply for each. At the end Þórr arrives and threatens him with his hammer, and Loki leaves. Two stanzas show the poem's edge. First Loki reminds Óðinn of their bond: "Odin! dost thou remember when we in early days blended our blood together?" Then Þórr, on arriving: "Silence, thou impure being! My mighty hammer, Miollnir, shall stop thy prating. I will thy head from thy neck strike; then will thy life be ended." (Stanzas 9 and 57, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866.)

A short prose ending in the manuscript tells what follows. The gods catch Loki, who had hidden as a salmon, and bind him with the entrails of his son. Skaði hangs a serpent over his face. His wife, Sigyn, holds a bowl to catch the venom. When she turns away to empty it, the venom drips on him, and his struggling shakes the earth.

Where this comes from: The Lokasenna and its prose ending are in the Poetic Edda. The excerpts are Benjamin Thorpe's 1866 translation, now public domain.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Think of a hard thing someone once said to you that held some truth. Write the words and the truth in them. Give it two dated lines.*

Poem log: write each poem you read, the date, one line that stayed with you, and one question it left.

Threshold

Who were the Old Norse

Who Were the Old Norse

The Old Norse were the people of Scandinavia and the North Atlantic, mostly from about 750 to 1050 CE, a time called the Viking Age. They were not one kingdom. They lived on farms, islands, and fjords in what is now Norway, Denmark, Sweden, and Iceland, and the sea was their main road. They spoke Old Norse, a North Germanic language, and cut it in runes, letters carved into stone and wood.

We know them through two kinds of record. Stones and graves show what people left behind: names, burials, tools, and ships. Books tell the stories, and they were written down later, mostly in Iceland. The Poetic Edda is a collection of old poems about gods and heroes. Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda retells the myths in plain prose. Icelandic sagas are prose stories about families and kings.

Stones keep what people finished, and stories keep what people cared about. You need both. On each page I will tell you which kind of record I am using.

Where this comes from: Runestones and the Viking Age dates come from archaeology. The Poetic Edda and Snorri's Prose Edda were copied down centuries later.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Tonight, spend half an hour at your table. Read one short passage, then write whether it is a stone record or a story record. Write three lines and date them today.*

Who Were the Old Norse

No Viking wrote a handbook of belief for us to find. Most of what we know comes from people who were not Vikings, or who lived long after. The Roman writer Tacitus described Germanic peoples around 98 CE, from outside, for a Roman audience. The Arab traveler Ibn Fadlan watched a chieftain's funeral on the Volga River in 922 and wrote it down as a stranger. Icelandic Christians copied the old poems and sagas onto vellum, a prepared animal skin, in the 1200s. They saved the voices, but they changed the frame.

That means the record has gaps, and this book says so. It is about the Old Norse only. It is not Celtic lore with Norse names, and it is not a modern mix pretending to be old. When modern people have filled a gap, I say so plainly, and I name the source of everything else. Every lore page ends with a note called "Where this comes from."

Ask who wrote each source and why, and you will know how far to trust it.

Where this comes from: How this book works. Its method is modern, but it is built on old sources.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Write one sentence for what you hope this book will give you, and one for what you hope it will leave out. Write both tonight and date them today.*

The wary guest

The Hávamál (Havamal), the "Sayings of the High One," is a poem in the Poetic Edda full of advice from Óðinn. It values a clear head over a high mood. Stanza 7 describes the wise guest: "A wary guest, who to refection comes, keeps a cautious silence, with his ears listens, and with his eyes observes: so explores every prudent man." (Translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866.)

The practice is the wary guest's. Before you enter a room, a meeting, or a hard conversation this week, stop at the door. Stay quiet at first, listen with your ears, and watch with your eyes. Notice what is happening before you decide what to say.

Do this once a day for a week, and write one line each time on what you noticed. A clear head matters too: the Hávamál warns that too much drink steals the mind. Test the old advice for yourself.

Where this comes from: The counsel and the quotation are from the Hávamál in the Poetic Edda, in Benjamin Thorpe's 1866 translation, now public domain. The practice builds on stanza 7.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Tonight, stop at one doorway before you enter, and listen. Write what you heard and saw. Give it three dated lines.

What did you notice at the door? Name what you heard, what you saw, and what you chose not to say.

Noticing log, day one. Go to a spot where you can watch and listen. Date it. Write three things you see and three you hear.

Nine Realms

The Gods and Their Kingdoms

Creation: fire meets mist

Before anything had a name, there was a gap. The Old Norse called it Ginnungagap, probably "the yawning gap." It was not a person but a place: a huge empty space with fire on one side and ice on the other. Múspell (Muspell), the fire world, burned at one edge, guarded by the giant Surtr (Surt) with a flaming sword. Niflheimr (Niflheim), the mist world, lay at the other, where poisonous rivers froze into frost.

Then fire and ice met. Sparks from Múspell crossed the gap and melted the frost into drops, and the drops became Ymir, the first giant. A cow named Auðumla (Audumla) fed on the salty ice until a man named Búri (Buri) appeared. He was the grandfather of Óðinn (Odin). Óðinn and his brothers killed Ymir and made the world from his body: earth from his flesh, sea from his blood, sky from his skull, mountains from his bones, and trees from his hair.

People came last. In Snorri Sturluson's Gylfaginning, three gods found two fallen trees on a shore, Ask and Embla, ash and elm. The gods gave them breath, wit, and warmth, and the trees stood up as the first people. You can take a small version of this home. When you bake bread or mend a seam, you give care to plain material.

Where this comes from: The creation story is from the Völuspá (Voluspa), Vafþrúðnismál (Vafthrudnismal), and Grímnismál (Grimnismal) in the Poetic Edda, and from Snorri's Prose Edda. The household use was written for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What are you building with your hands this season? Name the project, its stage, and its next step. Give it three dated lines.*

Nine Realms: sky, middle, and wild

The Old Norse told of nine realms, or worlds, held together by one great tree, Yggdrasill (Yggdrasil). They were not stacked like floors. Ásgarðr (Asgard) is the high home of the Æsir (Aesir) gods, such as Óðinn and Þórr, reached by the rainbow bridge Bifröst (Bifrost). Miðgarðr (Midgard) is the middle world where people live. Jörmungandr (Jormungandr), the world serpent, coils in the sea around its edge.

Vanaheimr (Vanaheim) is the home of the Vanir, an older family of gods tied to harvest and plenty, such as Njörðr (Njord), Freyr, and Freyja. Jötunheimr (Jotunheim) is the wild land of the jötnar (giants), who stand for chaos and untamed nature. The Æsir and the giants are often at odds.

Neither the Poetic Edda nor Snorri's Prose Edda gives one map of the nine realms. The ring-shaped diagram you may have seen is a modern way to draw them. Use the realms to check your week. The Æsir bring oath and order. The Vanir bring harvest and plenty. The giants bring the wild edges you cannot fully control. Which one does your week live in most, and which one is it missing?

Where this comes from: The realms and Bifröst are named in the Poetic Edda and Snorri's Prose Edda. The ring-shaped map was drawn for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Look at your week and name the realm it lives in most: order, harvest, wild edges, or something else. Write three dated lines: one on that realm, and two on where your week is missing one.*

Nine Realms: light, dark, fire, ice, and the dead

Álfheimr (Alfheim) is the bright home of the light elves. Svartálfaheimr (Svartalfheim), also called Niðavellir (Nidavellir) in some sources, is the underground home of the dwarfs and dark elves, whose smiths forged the gods' finest treasures.

Múspell is the world of fire, ruled by the giant Surtr. Niflheimr (Niflheim) is the world of ice and fog. At its center is the spring Hvergelmir, and one root of Yggdrasill reaches down to it. The two worlds stand on opposite sides of the gap where the world was made.

Hel is the world of the dead, ruled by a giantess also named Hel. In Snorri's Prose Edda she receives those who die of old age or sickness, not in battle. This book does not describe the road there. The practice is simpler: keep the names of your dead in use, as you do on the Ancestors pages.

Where this comes from: These realms are named in the Poetic Edda and Snorri's Prose Edda. The name Niðavellir and the sorting of elves into light and dark come from later sources.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name one thing in your life that shines, one that is cold or dark, and one that burns. Write a dated line for each. Give it three dated lines.*

Yggdrasill: the ash that holds

Yggdrasill is a giant ash tree that holds the nine worlds together. Its three roots reach three wells: Hvergelmir in Niflheimr, the well of Mímir (Mimir), and the well of Urðr (Urd), where the Nornir (Norns) sit and shape fate. A stag feeds on its shoots above. The squirrel Ratatoskr (Ratatosk) runs up and down the trunk carrying messages, and he scolds both ends as he goes.

Read the tree as a picture of how things connect, not as a road map. No source describes a home ritual for it, so this book does not invent one. What you can take home is simple. Everything depends on something else. Roots need water. News travels the trunk like gossip. What you feed at the roots shows up later in the leaves.

Give your roots steady care, such as sleep, regular meals, and honest talk. Notice which roots are dry this week, and water one of them on purpose.

Where this comes from: The tree and its tenants are described in the Poetic Edda and Snorri's Prose Edda.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Draw your life as a tree tonight, with roots, trunk, and crown. Mark three roots that feed you and two branches you tend. Name one voice that scolds you, like Ratatoskr. Date it with today's date.*

Where the dead go: Valhöll (Valhalla), Fólkvangr (Folkvangr), Hel

The dead do not all go to one place. Valhöll (Valhalla) is Óðinn's hall, roofed with shields and raftered with spears, and it takes half of those slain in battle. Freyja takes the other half to Fólkvangr (Folkvangr), her own field. Hel keeps those who die of sickness or old age in her fenced hall, which is neither burning nor shining. A grim shore is set aside for oath-breakers and murderers. Baldr went down to Hel, and he stayed there after the ransom failed.

Valhöll and Fólkvangr appear in the Poetic Edda. Hel's hall appears in Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda and in the Poetic Edda, both written down late. Burial mounds tell a plainer story. They hold grave goods, ship settings, and feasting gear, which show care for the journey. Stories and mound earth are two kinds of witness. Neither cancels the other, and you can hold both while you grieve.

Your memory of someone is a form of care. It can last longer than any set of beliefs. You do not need the right belief to honor them. You need to keep their name in use. Speak it, write it, and keep one thing they loved in your home.

Where this comes from: Valhöll, Fólkvangr, and Hel are described in the Poetic Edda and Snorri's Prose Edda, both copied down late. The mounds are known from archaeology.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name one person who is gone and one thing they cared about. Name the place you picture them resting. Give it three plain lines with today's date.*

Ragnarok: winter without spring

Ragnarök (Ragnarok) is the end of the world, told in the Völuspá. First comes Fimbulwinter, three winters in a row with no summer between. Families break their promises to one another, and an age of axes begins. The sun darkens and the stars fall. Naglfar, a ship made of dead men's nails, floats free. Heimdallr (Heimdall) blows his horn, and the gods ride out to the plain of Vígríðr (Vigrid).

There they fight. Óðinn falls to the wolf Fenrir. Þórr (Thor) kills the world serpent and falls dead nine steps later. Loki and Heimdallr kill each other. Fire burns the world.

But the poem does not stop there. Earth rises green from the sea a second time. Baldr and Höðr (Hodr) return, and Víðarr (Vidar) and Váli (Vali) live on. The golden game pieces the gods once played with are found again in the grass. When something in your life ends, look for what grows after it. Name the ending, then find one small sign of new growth. You can grieve the loss and still look for it.

Where this comes from: The doom and the greening are from the Völuspá, retold in Snorri's Prose Edda. This book offers no rites for the end of the world.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name one ending in your life. Name what grew after it, even something small. Give it three dated lines and read them aloud once.*

Doors: mounds and edges

In many old stories you cross into another world at an edge, not at a center. In Icelandic stories, burial mounds are said to stand open at Yule, the mid-winter feast, and the dead walk near the living. A mound, a shoreline, and a feast night are all places where one world touches another.

Treat this as a story pattern, not a literal gate. Mounds mark crossing points in Icelandic sagas, and the Yule opening comes mostly from later Icelandic folk belief. Some farms still leave certain hills and landing places alone. That is folk custom, related to the stories but separate from them. Your own street can feel different at dusk. That feeling is real, but it is your own, not proof about other worlds.

Use the pattern to pay attention. Go out at dusk and notice the edges near you: a gate, a water line, a crossing. Write down what changes at each one.

Where this comes from: Mounds as doors appear in Icelandic sagas. The idea that they open at Yule comes from later Icelandic folk belief.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Walk your block for ten minutes tonight and pick three edge spots. Give each spot one line for what changes there. Read the three aloud and circle the one that feels strongest. Date them with today's date.*

Guest rules: Hávamál manners

The Hávamál is full of house rules for guests and hosts. It tells a traveler to look around before he sits down, to speak little, and to listen long. It tells him never to mock a guest or a host. In the old songs, oath-breakers lose their good name.

These rules make sense as household habits first and as scholarship second. Folk custom keeps related rules in Yule peace and threshold greetings, which are related but not the same. Today, turn the rules around. You are the host in your own home, and your home tells visitors what to expect.

Your own table can follow one rule: no guest should leave hungry. Make that a habit.

Where this comes from: The guest rules are from the Hávamál.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Write three rules you would post for tired guests. Keep each one short enough for an index card. Tape the card inside a cupboard and read it each day for a week. Date it with today's date.*

Crooked time: promises across winter

The Old Norse did not always tell a story in a straight line. The Völuspá starts at the beginning of the world, jumps forward into doom, then past it into green earth rising again. Their year worked the same way. Icelanders counted years in winters, and oaths sworn at Yule were meant to hold through the summer, so a vow spoken on a winter night came due in spring.

Your own year works this way too. School terms and work rotas set the pace, and anniversaries arrive before you feel ready. A promise made in winter comes due in spring.

Pick one promise you made this winter and check it against the spring. Ask whether it still stands, and what it asks of you now. A written promise is easier to keep than a remembered one. Put a reminder on your calendar for the first warm day of spring.

Where this comes from: The looping style is in the Völuspá and Icelandic sagas, and winter-counting is in the sagas.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Pick one promise you made this winter and write it tonight in pencil. Write what you agreed to, what spring must bring, and what autumn must close. Fold the page and keep it where you get dressed. Date it.*

Rǫgn: Gods & Ruling Powers

Aesir & Vanir

Æsir and Vanir: The God Tribes

Rǫgn is an old Norse word for the powers: the gods and the forces that rule the world. The gods come in two families. The Æsir include Óðinn, Þórr, and Frigg. They live in Ásgarðr, the high realm in the sky, and they care about oath, battle, and order. The Vanir include Njörðr, Freyr, and Freyja. They live in Vanaheimr and care about the sea, the harvest, and plenty. Giants and elves live in other realms and belong to neither family.

The two families once fought a war and then made peace. The next page tells how it ended. Scholars think the story may remember two peoples who later joined together. It comes to us from the Völuspá, the seeress's prophecy in the Poetic Edda, and from Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda, written around 1220. Both were written down centuries after the Viking Age, so the details are uncertain.

Think of the two families as two households that learned to share one valley. Each keeps its own job. The Æsir keep oath and order, and the Vanir keep work and plenty. A home that has only one of them is missing something.

Where this comes from: The Æsir and Vanir are in the Völuspá (Poetic Edda) and Snorri's Prose Edda, both copied late. The idea that they were once two peoples is a scholars' theory, not proven.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which job is missing in your home right now: oath and order, or work and plenty? Write one dated line about it and what you will do this week.*

The Æsir–Vanir war

The Æsir and Vanir once fought a war. The Völuspá says the Æsir broke a truce, and the Vanir fought back. Neither side could win for good, so they made peace.

The peace was built on hostages, a person from each side sent to live with the other. Njörðr and Freyr went to live among the Æsir. Hænir (Hoenir) and Mímir (Mimir) went to the Vanir. A hostage was a guest, fed and treated well, and that gave both sides a reason to keep their word. A promise is easy to break. A person sitting at the other table is harder to forget.

Njörðr and Freyr spent time in Ásgarðr as part of the treaty, but their home is Vanaheimr. The stories do not describe life after the treaty, so think of it this way: each family has its own home and its own job, and they meet at the table. The Völuspá and Snorri's Prose Edda tell this as medieval Icelandic story, not as history of a real war.

Where this comes from: The war and the hostage exchange are told in the Völuspá and Snorri's Prose Edda, both copied late.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name one quarrel in your life and the person on the other side. Invite them to one shared meal this month, and write one dated line about it.*

The gods at a glance

Æsir
Óðinn: wisdom, poetry, war, and the dead.
Frigg: foresight, marriage, and the household.
Þórr: thunder, and guardian of people against giants.
Sif: Þórr's wife, with golden hair.
Týr: oaths, law, and battle.
Baldr: the shining, beloved son of Óðinn and Frigg.
Heimdallr: the watchman of the gods.

Vanir
Njörðr: sea, wind, and wealth; father of Freyr and Freyja.
Freyr: harvest, fair weather, and peace.
Freyja: love, plenty, and half of the slain.

Others
Loki: the trickster, and father of Hel, Fenrir, and Jörmungandr.
Skaði: giantess of mountains and winter, wife of Njörðr for a time.
Sól and Máni: the sun and the moon, sister and brother.

Where this comes from: The Poetic Edda and Snorri's Prose Edda.

Óðinn: the one-eyed

Óðinn (Odin) is the chief of the Æsir, the high one, and the god of wisdom, poetry, war, and the dead. He rides the eight-legged horse Sleipnir, shown on picture stones and thin gold medallions called bracteates. Two ravens, Huginn and Muninn, fly out each day and bring him news: thought and memory. Two wolves, Geri and Freki, follow at his heels. The Eddas also call him Alföðr (Allfather).

He paid a high price for wisdom. He gave one eye to the well of Mímir (Mimir) for a drink of its water. He hung nine nights on Yggdrasill, wounded by his own spear, to win the runes. The Hávamál gives his long counsel on wits and measure. The Poetic Edda shows him generous and terrible by turns, and he breaks oaths too.

Later books make him a kindly Allfather for modern worship, which is a modern softening. Jackson Crawford, a modern scholar of Old Norse, has argued that the name Alföðr may mean 'All Order' rather than 'All-Father'. This reading is debated, and this book does not settle it.

The lesson is in the price. Óðinn wants to know things, and that hunger never comes free. Steady attention counts for more than an altar nobody visits. Give a set hour each week to learning a real craft, a poem, or a history.

Where this comes from: Óðinn's eye, hanging, ravens, wolves, and horse are in the Poetic Edda, Snorri's Prose Edda, and on stones. The 'All Order' reading is Jackson Crawford's, and it is debated.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What hard thing will you learn for Óðinn? Name the poem or craft or history, the hour, and twice this week. Give it two dated lines.*

Óðinn — practice

The practice is study, not asking. A chapter of the Hávamál in translation can serve. So can learning a row of runes one letter at a time, or reading Egils saga (Egil's Saga) ten pages at a sitting. Sit at the same hour twice a week and stay long enough for the work to sink in. Learn names and verses first. Patience is the manners of this practice.

The offering is attention, not a deal. Nothing is bargained for. Copying verses by hand fits here, and so does memorizing three stanzas. These are reconstructed gestures, built on the old pattern of seeking counsel. Jackson Crawford puts it this way: "As Odin sought wisdom from the dead, so too do we seek wisdom from those who have passed when we read their words."

Keep each session under half an hour, with your hands free and your phone away. At the end, write one line on what you learned. Coming back is the vow you keep.

Where this comes from: The study practice was rebuilt for this book from the old pattern. The quotation is Jackson Crawford's.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name the study you will keep twice this week and the hour you will keep it. Give it under half an hour each time with phone away. Give it two dated lines on what you learned.*

Frigg: wife and seer

Frigg is the wife of Óðinn and the mother of Baldr. She sits beside the high seat and sees further than she tells. She knows what will come and speaks of it to almost no one. She spins and weaves and keeps the keys and inner doors of the household.

Two stories show her. In the Lokasenna, a poem in the Poetic Edda, she warns Loki that Baldr would have made him pay for his insults, and Loki answers that he is the reason Baldr never rides home. In Snorri's Prose Edda, when Baldr dreams of his death, she makes everything in the world swear not to harm him. She works by foresight and preparation.

Some scholars think Frigg and Freyja may be two names for one goddess. Here Frigg holds marriage and household foresight, and Freyja holds love and growth. In your home, Frigg stands for planning ahead. Look at what winter will ask of your home: lamp oil, savings, rest. Lay one thing ready this week, and cool quarrels before they catch fire.

Where this comes from: Frigg's foresight is in the Poetic Edda, and her oath-taking for Baldr is in Snorri's Prose Edda. Scholars debate whether she and Freyja were once one goddess.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Look ahead one season: what does your household see coming, and what will you lay ready? Name lamp oil or savings or rest and lay one thing ready this week. Give it two dated lines.*

Freyja of Fólkvangr

Freyja is the lady of the Vanir, and her name means "lady." She takes half of those slain in battle to her own field, Fólkvangr, and the other half goes to Óðinn. She owns the necklace Brísingamen (Brisingamen), drives a cart drawn by cats, and wears a feather cloak that lets her fly. She knows the craft of love and of fate.

In the Þrymskviða (Thrymskvida), the giant Þrymr steals Þórr's hammer and demands Freyja as his bride. She refuses to be traded, and her anger shakes the halls. Þórr dresses as the bride instead and gets the hammer back. Some scholars think Freyja and Frigg may once have been one goddess, but this book keeps their roles separate.

She stands for plenty and for the right to choose. You may refuse a bad deal outright, and welcome a fair one that brings growth. Say no to any deal that treats you as a price, and keep your worth steady through hard weeks.

Where this comes from: Fólkvangr, the necklace, and the feather cloak are in the Poetic Edda. The cat-cart is in Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda. Scholars debate whether Freyja and Frigg were once one goddess.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name a time you refused to be traded. Name what you kept and how you kept it. Give it three dated lines with the refusal plain.*

Freyr of harvest and peace

Freyr is the Vanir lord of harvest, fair weather, and peace, and his name means “lord.” He owns the ship Skíðblaðnir (Skidbladnir), which folds up like cloth, and the boar Gullinbursti, with golden bristles. Kings called him an ancestor, and farmers called on him for rain.

In the Skírnismál (Skirnismal), Freyr falls in love with Gerðr (Gerd), a giant maid, and sends his servant Skírnir to win her with gifts and then threats. To get her, Freyr gives away his own sword, and Snorri says he goes to Ragnarök without it. Adam of Bremen later describes a fertility god at Uppsala, usually read as Freyr. That account is late and written from a Christian point of view.

His gifts come with a limit. Plenty can turn into greed. Ask yourself what you grew that deserves sharing this season. Pick one loaf, one jar, or one mended thing. Show it to one witness and share it the same day.

Where this comes from: The Skírnismál is in the Poetic Edda. The Uppsala account is late and written from a Christian point of view.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What increase deserves sharing this season? Name the loaf or jar or mended thing and the witness. Share it the same day with two dated lines.*

Þórr: driver of the goat cart

Þórr (Thor) is the thunder god of the Æsir and the strongest of them. He drives a cart pulled by two goats, Tanngnjóstr (Tooth-Gnasher) and Tanngrisnir (Tooth-Gritter), and the cart throws sparks as it goes. He has a red beard and the hammer Mjölnir (Mjollnir). He guards Miðgarðr, the world of people, against the giants.

In the Þrymskviða poem a giant steals his hammer, and Þórr dresses as a bride to win it back. The hammer is used to bless the bride, and small hammer amulets show that people in the north wore it for protection. His job, as the sources show it, is guarding the edges of life: a wedding, the border of a field, and the launch of a ship. The practice below is a reconstruction built on that pattern.

In your own life, this is the work of keeping the boundaries other people rely on. Think of his cart stopping at your gate. The gate latch gets fixed, the inbox gets sorted, and the bedtime routine stays steady. Walk one errand in bad weather. Mending a thing keeps faith with the people who depend on it.

Where this comes from: Þórr's hammer, goats, and hallowing are in the Poetic Edda and Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda, and hammer amulets survive.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Who does the sheltering in your life? Name the boundary you most depend on and the mending that is yours this week. Give it gate or inbox or bedtime with a date. Give it two dated lines.

Skaði: winter's bride

Skaði (Skadi) is a giantess of the mountains and winter, a hunter on skis with a bow. When the gods kill her father, the giant Þjazi (Thiazi), she arms herself and strides into Ásgarðr to take revenge.

The gods offer her a settlement instead. She may choose a husband from among them, but she can see only their feet. She picks the handsomest feet, hoping for Baldr, and finds she has chosen Njörðr, the sea god. The gods also make her laugh, when Loki ties a cord between himself and a goat. Óðinn throws Þjazi's eyes into the sky as stars. The marriage is short. She loves the mountains and he loves the sea, so they part, each to their own shore.

Þórr himself boasts of killing Þjazi in the Harbarðsljóð (Harbardsljod). Read her as a story about terms kept. The price is named and paid, and each person lives where they thrive. Plain terms settle a bargain: say what is owed, say what will settle it, and say which place each party keeps afterward.

Where this comes from: Skaði's settlement is in Snorri's Prose Edda, and Þórr's boast is in the Harbarðsljóð, both late. The household use was written for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What bargain of yours needs plain terms, and which shore will each party keep? Name what is owed and what settles it. Give it three dated lines and speak it before the week ends.*

Loki: The Trickster

No devil stands here, whatever later sermons made of him. Snorri's Gylfaginning says Loki was born a giant, the son of Fárbauti and Laufey, and the old texts sometimes name him for his mother, Laufey's son. He lives among the Æsir in Ásgarðr, and in the Lokasenna he reminds Óðinn that the two swore blood-brotherhood. With the giantess Angrboða he fathered Hel, the wolf Fenrir, and the world serpent. His mischief starts small and turns costly. In Snorri's Prose Edda he cuts off the golden hair of Sif, the wife of Þórr, and Þórr threatens to break every bone in him. Loki goes to the dwarfs for new hair, and the gifts he brings back include Þórr's hammer. The harm grows. He arranges the death of Baldr, and in the Lokasenna he insults every god at a feast until Þórr threatens him with his hammer and he leaves. At last the gods bind him in a cave with a serpent's venom dripping on him. At Ragnarök he breaks free. He is clever, cruel, and useful.

He is cleverness without loyalty, and he cannot be flattered into favors. If trouble with him comes near, bring repair and nothing else. Own the mess and repair it fully, facing the person you hurt directly. The binding and the insults are told in the Poetic Edda and Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda. Soft modern readings that make him a misunderstood friend belong elsewhere, not here.

Clear thinking does cold work here, like a knife paring rot from wood. List your tangles. Strike the ones that are only noise. Keep the one that is truly a mess to mend. Clarity is the only answer he respects. One cleanly repaired tangle is worth more than a year of excuses.

Where this comes from: Loki's parentage and the story of Sif are in Snorri's Prose Edda. His blood-brotherhood with Óðinn and his binding are in the Lokasenna.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Sort it out: which tangle is your mess to mend, and which is only noise? Name the one mess. Give it one dated line tonight.*

Baldr: The Light

Baldr is the shining son of Óðinn and Frigg, and the best loved of the gods. The sources tell little about him, so this page is short on purpose. His dreams show him doomed. His mother makes everything in the world swear not to harm him, but she overlooks the mistletoe. Loki guides the hand of Baldr's blind brother Höðr (Hodr), who shoots him with it.

All things mourn Baldr, but he is held in Hel after the ransom weeping fails. Hermóðr (Hermod) rides down to ask for him back and returns empty-handed. Grief is most of what the sources give him.

He gets one page and one use: the beloved who is lost. Claims that he is a dying god like others around the world, or a Christ-like figure, are modern, and this book sets them aside without scorn. We all lose something that brought us light, and Baldr can stand for that. Keep one grief on the page all month, without forcing it to teach you anything. Name the missed person in one true sentence.

Where this comes from: Baldr's death is in the Poetic Edda and Snorri's Prose Edda, copied late. The idea of a dying god is a modern comparison.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What beloved loss sits with you still? Name who is missed in one true sentence. Give it a day and one dated line.*

Týr (Tyr) of the oath

Týr (Tyr) is the god of oaths and law, and a god of battle and victory. He is best known for losing his right hand. The gods wanted to bind the wolf Fenrir, Loki's son, who had grown too strong. Fenrir would let them tie him only if one of them put a hand in his mouth as a pledge. Týr did, and when the chain held and Fenrir could not break free, the wolf bit the hand off.

The story is told in Snorri's Prose Edda, and the lost hand is named in the Lokasenna. The Sigrdrífumál and the medieval rune poems (Norwegian, Icelandic, and Anglo-Saxon) name his rune for victory. Þórr guards by strength, and Týr guards by oath.

Choose one pledge this week. Make it short enough to keep without footnotes. Say it to one witness, state the cost, and keep it exactly. A kept promise is what makes your word trusted tomorrow.

Where this comes from: The binding of Fenrir is in Snorri's Prose Edda, and Týr's rune is in the rune poems and the Sigrdrífumál.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which oath of yours needs a hand behind it? Name it short enough to keep without footnotes. Speak it to one witness and give it one dated line.*

Heimdallr: watchman

Heimdallr (Heimdall) is the watchman of the gods. He guards Bifröst, the rainbow bridge to Ásgarðr, and he hardly sleeps. His hearing is so keen he can hear grass grow. He owns the horn Gjallarhorn, which will sound at the last day. He was born of nine mothers at the edge of the sea, as the Hyndluljóð (Hyndluljod) tells it.

In the Lokasenna he tells Loki he is drunk and should go home. Snorri says the two will kill each other at Ragnarök, watcher against trickster.

His lesson is the watch. Keep one bridge faithfully: a door, an inbox, or your temper. Stand ten minutes daily at the same post with your eyes up and note what moved. Trouble caught early is easier to handle while it is small. Speak warnings plainly before the cost grows.

Where this comes from: Heimdallr appears in the Hyndluljóð, Lokasenna, and Völuspá in the Poetic Edda, and in Snorri's Prose Edda.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name your bridge and your watch-hour. Stand ten minutes daily at the same post with phone away. Give it one dated line daily and one early warning this week.*

Days of the week

The Romans invented our seven-day week and named each day for a god or heavenly body: the Sun, Moon, Mars, Mercury, Jupiter, Venus, and Saturn. In the first centuries CE, Germanic peoples, the ancestors of the Norse and English, began using it.

They kept the week but not the Roman gods. For each Roman god they chose the Germanic god who seemed closest.

Sunday · sunnudagr
Sól, the sun goddess, who drives the sun across the sky.

Monday · mánadagr
Máni, the moon god and Sól's brother, who drives the moon across the sky.

Tuesday · týsdagr
Týr, god of oaths and law. He was also a god of battle and victory, so he was matched with Rome's Mars, god of war.

Wednesday · óðinsdagr
Óðinn, the high one. He wandered in disguise, ruled poetry and speech, and received the dead, so he was matched with Rome's Mercury, god of speech.

Thursday · þórsdagr
Þórr, the thunderer. He ruled thunder and carried the hammer Mjölnir, so he was matched with Rome's Jupiter, who wielded the thunderbolt.

Friday · frjádagr
Frigg, Óðinn's wife and goddess of marriage, so she was matched with Rome's Venus, goddess of love. Some scholars think Freyja.

Saturday · laugardagr
The Norse named it for bathing, not a god. *Laug* means "bath," so *laugardagr* is "washing day." English kept Rome's Saturn.

Where this comes from: The Poetic Edda and Snorri's Prose Edda.

Jörmungandr: the world serpent

Jörmungandr (Jormungandr) is a giant sea serpent. He is one of three monstrous children of Loki and the giantess Angrboða. The other two are the wolf Fenrir and Hel, who rules the dead. In Snorri's Prose Edda, the gods feared all three, and Óðinn threw the serpent into the deep sea around Miðgarðr (Midgard), the world of people. There he grew until he circled the whole world with his tail in his mouth.

Þórr is his great enemy. In the Hymiskviða (Hymiskvitha), Þórr goes fishing with the giant Hymir and uses an ox head as bait. Jörmungandr bites. Þórr hauls him up to the boat, but Hymir cuts the line, and the serpent sinks back into the sea.

At Ragnarök, Jörmungandr rises from the sea and floods the land. Þórr kills him, then walks nine steps and falls dead from the serpent's venom.

He is a monster, not a god, and the old sources show no one praying to him. He stands for a danger too big to beat alone. Name one problem you cannot fix this week, and one thing you will do to stay safe around it. Like thin winter ice, some things can be crossed only with care.

Where this comes from: The fishing trip is in the Hymiskviða. His birth, his throwing into the sea, and the final fight are in Snorri's Prose Edda. This book offers no way to call him.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name the problem you cannot master this season, and the edge you will walk carefully. Lay one store ready and mend one boundary and speak one warning. Give it three dated lines.*

Landvættir (Landvaettir): land-spirits

Landvættir (landvaettir) are land spirits, the unseen guardians of a place. Icelandic stories and law treat them as real neighbors who must be respected. The Landnámabók, a book of Iceland's first settlers, says ships had to remove the carved heads from their prows before landing, so the spirits would not be frightened.

Egils saga shows how seriously people took them. The hero Egill raises a scorn pole, a post topped with a horse's head, and calls on the land spirits to drive out the king who wronged him.

The message is plain for any household: you are a guest on the land. Ask leave, keep your landing clean, and do not foul water or wood. Well-kept ground stays kinder than fouled ground, season after season.

Where this comes from: The ship rule is in the Landnámabók and the scorn pole is in Egils saga. The household lessons were written for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Tell me plainly: what ground do you stand on, and which landlord have you never thanked? Clear one path and leave one shore clean. Give it two dated lines.*

Landvættir — practice

Set aside the first and best part of your walk for the land. Bring a small bag so litter is never left behind. Carry out your litter. Keep to the path. Lower your noise near nesting ground. Share the shore rather than claim it. Keep any care small, and do it right away. Leave the place cleaner than you found it.

Count your visits month by month, shore by shore, so the habit stays honest. The pattern is leave-no-trace care, reconstructed from Egils saga and Grágás and fitted to a flat with boots and a bag. What is tended honestly stays welcoming longer than what is only praised.

Finish the visit inside an hour. Note the date and the place in your log before you go home. Walk the shore and pick up litter. End before supper. Repeat it monthly. Clean shores keep their welcome, the way swept doorsteps keep their visitors.

Where this comes from: The leave-no-trace practice was rebuilt for this book from Egils saga and Grágás.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *This month, what shore will you keep, and what will you carry out? Walk it inside the hour with boots and bag. Give it two dated lines for where and what.*

Nornir: The Norns

The Nornir (Norns) are the women who shape fate. The Völuspá names three: Urðr (Urd), Verðandi (Verdandi), and Skuld. Their names are often read as what has been, what is becoming, and what must be.

They live beside the well of Urðr at the foot of Yggdrasill, the world tree. There they carve the lengths of lives and water the tree each day. In Snorri's Prose Edda, other Norns come to every birth to shape that person's life, some kind and some cruel.

Fate and luck are not the same. Fate is the pattern the Norns set, and you cannot choose it. Luck, called hamingja, moves with how you act. Keep your oaths, pay what you owe on time, and give something freely each week.

Where this comes from: The Norns and their well are in the Völuspá in the Poetic Edda. Snorri's Prose Edda adds the Norns at birth. The idea of luck is in Egils saga.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Where stands your luck today: rising, steady, or spent? Name what moved it and one restoring act. Give it two dated lines.*

Valkyries: choosers

A valkyrie (Old Norse valkyrja, “chooser of the slain”) is a warrior woman who serves Óðinn. Valkyries ride to battles and choose who will die, then bring the chosen dead to Valhöll, Óðinn’s hall, where they serve ale to the fallen. The Grímnismál names several: Hrist, Mist, and Skeggjöld.

In the Sigrdrífumál (Sigrdrifumal), the hero Sigurðr wakes a sleeping valkyrie, Sigrdrífa, whom Völsunga saga calls Brynhildr. She teaches him rune counsel: victory runes for the sword, ale runes for the horn, and birth runes for childbirth.

Her counsel is the part you can use. Before a hard day, ask one elder or steady friend for advice, and say your terms aloud so they can hear. Hard tasks go better with one clear voice beside you.

Where this comes from: The valkyrie names are in the Grímnismál in the Poetic Edda, and the counsel is in the Sigrdrífumál. This book offers no rites for calling valkyries.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name your battle this week, and whose counsel will you seek before it? Ask one elder or steady friend and speak your terms aloud. Give it three dated lines for battle, counsel, and terms.*

Blot: simply

A blót (blot) was an old offering feast. In Hákonar saga góða, part of Snorri Sturluson's Heimskringla, people gather and a gift is given. Blood is caught and sprinkled with twigs on the walls and on the people. Toasts are drunk in order: to the gods, to the ancestors, and to victory. Then everyone feasts on the gift itself. The full cup is the toast to the gods, and the minni cup is the toast to memory, passed hand to hand.

The old hall shrinks to a table here, and this book does not pretend to rebuild it. The modern blot has three acts. Set out a gift of water, milk, bread, song, or work, never more than you can spare. Speak aloud the names of who receives it. Eat a share or carry it out, with thanks. Nothing is buried. Nothing is poured where it fouls water. No coins are left in springs.

The whole practice fits inside half an hour. Carry out every trace before you sleep. Repeat it at the next turn of the month. Passing the cup from hand to hand keeps memory alive.

Where this comes from: The toasts and blood-sprinkling are in Hákonar saga góða. The household blot was rebuilt for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What gift will you set out this month, and who receives it by name? Set water or milk or bread or song or work and drink the toast. Give it four dated lines in the tracker.*

Offering log: what did you give, to whom, and what came back?

- ☐ Water / milk / bread / song / work — date each
- ☐ To whom — name the figure
- ☐ What you asked, in one line
- ☐ What you offered back
- ☐ Leave-no-trace check (carried out?)
- ☐ Week two offering
- ☐ Week three offering
- ☐ Week four offering

Völva & Seiðr

seeress and fate-work

Völva: staff-bearer

A völva (volva) is a seeress, a woman who carries a staff and sees what is hidden. The Völuspá is a völva speaking. She is called to the hall of Óðinn and paid to remember. She tells what was: the giants, the dwarfs, and the world tree. Then she tells what comes: winter, breaking, and the last battle. Picture her staff leaning by your chair.

The poem also tells of Heiðr (Heidr), a woman who worked fate craft among households. She was burned three times and born again, never fully welcome and never dismissed.

Read the völva as a witness, not a fortune-teller. The poem gives her words, not her method. No trance steps, drum patterns, or seating plans survive in the Poetic Edda, and this book will not invent them. Guided trance, costume, and ticketed prophecy are modern.

Meet her text honestly at the table with the book open. Read the Völuspá slowly across three sittings, ten stanzas at a time. Write down what it warns about for the week in plain words. Ask one elder for a long memory to set beside it, and date each note so you can see how your questions change. Listening to real people beats buying a fortune.

Where this comes from: The seeress speaking is in the Völuspá in the Poetic Edda. Trance scripts and modern divination sold as völva-work are modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Whose long memory will you ask for this month? Read ten stanzas at a sitting across three sittings. Ask one elder, and write plain dated lines beside the Völuspá.*

Seiðr: fate-work with limits

Seiðr (seidr) is a kind of magic tied to fate and spirits, and in the sources it belongs mostly to women. Two mentions in the Poetic Edda carry most of the weight, and both are unkind. In the Völuspá, the seeress says Heiðr practiced seiðr wherever she could, a fate worker moving from house to house. In the Lokasenna, Loki mocks Óðinn: he says Óðinn beat the drum like a seeress on Samsey and went about as a witch among men.

So seiðr is shown as powerful, risky, and mocked in the same breath. That is all the Poetic Edda says. No ritual, step order, dress code, or drum pattern survives. Any staged seiðr with a circle, staff dance, and guided oracle is modern, and so is any lot draw or card read sold as Viking seiðr.

The honest part happens at home. Pick one pattern in your house: late bills, a short temper, or kind help that repeats. Tilt it one degree this week by keeping an oath and giving a gift. A small tilt can turn a long road, the way a rudder turns a ship.

Where this comes from: Heiðr is in the Völuspá and the taunt about Samsey is in the Lokasenna, both in the Poetic Edda. Ritual scripts and divination uses are modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name one pattern in your house you will tilt one degree this week, and how? Give it oath kept and gift given. Give it three dated lines.*

Útiseta (Utiseta): sitting out

Útiseta (utiseta) means "sitting out." In Icelandic sagas, a person sits alone at night on a mound or at a crossroads, wrapped in a cloak, to win counsel the household could not give. Verses are sought and dreams are invited. The pattern repeats: alone, overnight, at an edge.

The sagas give the posture, not the steps. No seating plan, staff drill, or summoned voice survives in the sources, and scripted night sittings sold for tickets are modern. Keep it small and safe: a step or garden, with a door unlatched behind you.

Sit once a month for twenty minutes, at dusk or dawn. Carry one question out with you. Do not try to summon anything. Keep your attention open and write down what you noticed.

Where this comes from: Mound-sitting is in Icelandic sagas. No ritual survives, and this book offers none.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What single question will you carry out to the edge, and on which night? Sit twenty minutes at dusk or dawn with phone away. Give it three dated lines for light, sounds, and how you felt, paired with the three day sit log in Liminal Places.*

Hamingja

your luck

Hamingja: Your Luck

Hamingja is personal luck and family luck, and in Icelandic sagas it follows a person like a second skin. Men speak of luck as plainly as they speak of ships. It grows through generosity and oath-keeping and shrinks through stinginess and broken oaths. Good luck settles on the generous, and bad luck follows the oath breaker.

This page turns that idea into a thirty-day method. Pick one daily doing and one daily refusal, each short enough to say in one breath. Speak them to one witness, even if the witness is only this book held open. If you slip one day, mend it the next morning and log it as a mend. Thirty days is long enough to change a habit and short enough to finish.

Begin tomorrow. Each kept day adds to your record, and a full record shows you what you have changed. The luck idea is in the sagas. The thirty-day version is modern, fitted to the trackers that follow.

Where this comes from: The idea of luck is in the sagas. The 30-day practice was written for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *In your own words, what doing and what refusal would actually change your luck? Speak them to one witness to begin thirty days tomorrow. Log each day on the two Hamingja trackers that follow.*

Hamingja record, days 1–15: one doing and one refusal each day.

- ☐ Day 1 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 2 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 3 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 4 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 5 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 6 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 7 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 8 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 9 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 10 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 11 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 12 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 13 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 14 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 15 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

Hamingja record, days 16–30: one doing and one refusal each day.

☐ Day 16 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 17 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 18 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 19 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 20 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 21 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 22 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 23 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 24 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 25 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 26 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 27 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 28 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 29 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 30 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

Vitki

rune-reader

Vitki: Rune-Reader

A vitki is a person who works with runes. The old word means something close to "wise one." The clearest picture comes from Óðinn himself in the Hávamál. He hangs nine nights in a wind-tossed tree, hungry and thirsty, until he sees the runes below and seizes them with a shout. Then he carves them into wood and reddens the cuts with color.

In the Sigrdrífumál, the valkyrie Sigrdrífa, whom Völsunga saga calls Brynhildr, teaches the hero Sigurðr the same craft. She puts victory runes on the sword hilt, ale runes on the drinking horn, and birth runes on the palm. Knowing here is handwork: you cut, you color, and you speak it aloud.

The medieval rune poems (Norwegian, Icelandic, and Anglo-Saxon) are the alphabet book behind the craft. They hold one short verse for each rune letter, each tied to a plain thing: wealth must move, ice bears no weight, the sun steadies. What they never show is anyone laying runes out to tell fortunes. That is modern and should be called so.

Learn one rune letter a week from the rune poems. Cut or draw it on a wood scrap or card, and speak its verse aloud. Then set it to one honest household use, such as scoring the loaf before baking, marking a tool handle, or chalking a mark above the door. Hands learn what guessing cannot.

Where this comes from: The hanging is in the Hávamál, the counsel in the Sigrdrífumál, and the verses in the rune poems, with a parallel in Völsunga saga. Rune-spread divination is modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which stave will you carve first this week, and what will you mark with it? Cut or draw it and speak its verse aloud. Use it on a loaf, tool, or door and give it three dated lines for stave, verse, and marking.*

Elves & Dwarfs

neighbors and smiths

Bright elves and dark elves

Elves (álfar) are shy neighbors in the old poems. You mostly glimpse them at the edge of lamplight. The Grímnismál names Álfheimr as their home. The poems often pair them with the gods in the phrase "Æsir and elves," and the Lokasenna seats them at Ægir's feast. They are beautiful and dangerous outsiders, tied to mounds and fields, and they are neither angels nor demons.

Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda splits them into two groups: light-elves, bright as the sun to look at, and dark-elves, black as pitch, who live down in the earth. That split is late and tidy. The Poetic Edda names elves often but never draws the line cleanly. Some scholars think Snorri may be sorting dwarfs under another name, calling them the smiths of Svartálfaheimr, the dark-elf world. Treat the boundary as blurred.

Think of the elves as unseen neighbors who watch from the edge. You can honor them by stepping softly, keeping paths clear, and leaving one quiet place alone. Practice this in one corner of your week, not in all of it.

Where this comes from: Álfheimr is in Grímnismál, and the light and dark split is in Snorri's Prose Edda, which is late and tidy.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Name one spot near your home that feels quietly watched over. Name how you will keep it. Give it two dated lines.

Freyr: lord of Álfheimr

Álfheimr, the home of the elves, was given to Freyr. The Grímnismál says it was a tooth-gift, a gift marking a child's first tooth. The god was young and of the Vanir. No verse in the Poetic Edda explains what lordship over the elves meant in practice.

Lordship here means something like neighborliness, not rule. The gift binds the elves to him the way two farms share a fence. Read the verse itself before you build any practice on it. This book builds no rite that treats Freyr as king of the elves.

Freyr is linked to fair weather and good harvests on tame ground. Elves are linked to beauty and danger at the wild edge. You can see that border simply: put a pot by your door with tended soil inside, and leave wild seed heads beyond it. Mending the fence keeps the harvest safe.

Where this comes from: The tooth-gift is in Grímnismál. This book adds no elf-king rites.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which place in your life joins tame to wild? Name it, name how you tend it, and log it with the date in two lines.*

Álfablót (Alfablot): the closed door

Álfablót (alfablot) means "elf sacrifice." It was an autumn rite, and almost everything we know comes from one traveler. Sigvatr Þórðarson (Thordarson), a skald, or court poet, of King Óláfr (Olaf), went from farm to farm in Norway seeking a bed and was turned away. In his poem Austrfararvísur (Austrfararvisur), he says each farm was holding an álfablót, which was holy and closed to strangers. The doors were barred and no guest was taken in.

That closed door is nearly all outsiders saw of the rite. Sigvatr's poem is from the early eleventh century, written at about the time. It describes being shut out, not the ritual itself. No prayer, altar plan, or list of offerings survives. The sources support only a few plain points: autumn, closed doors, and family only. Later farm custom leaves food and drink at mounds and keeps certain hills alone, but that is folk custom and not the same rite.

You can keep the same spirit at home. Pick one evening, close the door to noise, eat quietly, and speak one thank-you aloud. This is one skald's account of farms, not a rule for every farm.

Where this comes from: The álfablót is in Sigvatr's Austrfararvísur, a poem from the time. No account of the rite itself survives.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *When will you bar your door early for one quiet meal with thanks? Name the date, the meal, and the people you will thank. Give it three dated lines.*

Elves in the ground

Elves are still present in place names long after the Poetic Edda falls quiet. Farms and fields across Norway and Sweden carry elf-names, and Álfheimr was even the name of a region. Some stones and mounds were left alone by plows, while the plows cut straight through everything else. Icelandic sagas describe mounds honored with toasts poured at the door-stone and paths swept clean. The dead inside were called mound-dwellers, and they were not always clearly separate from elves.

This is about the land, not about formal teachings. Place names last longer than the books that record them. Elf-names are shown on stones and in farm-names recorded in Landnámabók, and folk custom still shows farmers leaving certain mounds and hills alone. Iceland's huldufolk, the hidden people, kept the same courtesy the longest.

Your street may keep a version of this too, perhaps the corner no one builds on, or the tree no one cuts. You can do the same on your block: leave one tree, one patch of ground, or one corner alone. Leave it be, and do not take what is not yours.

Where this comes from: Elf place-names and mound-honor are in old records and folk custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Walk your block once this week and look for places people leave alone. Mark two spots. Give each one dated line.*

Honoring without summoning

Elves were not worshipped the way the gods were. No temple to elves has been found, and no priest is named for them. The one sign of honor on record is the closed autumn door. Offerings at mounds and hills in Icelandic sagas were small. They were poured or laid down and left alone, with no attempt to call anything up. The Lokasenna seats the elves among the gods at Ægir's feast. They are guests and witnesses, not servants.

The old practice was courtesy without command. People cleaned up edges and lowered noise near nesting ground. They asked leave before taking, and they gave thanks after. Nothing was summoned, bound, or bought. The mound toasts are a pattern in Icelandic sagas, and the quiet-edge practice is rebuilt from that pattern. It is good manners, not control.

Keep one edge this way: choose one patch of ground or one shared space. Ask before you take from it, give thanks after, and leave it quieter than you found it. That is all this practice asks.

Where this comes from: Mound offerings are in Icelandic sagas. This book offers no summoning rites.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which edge will you keep this month, using only good manners? Name place, act, and date in three lines.*

Born from earth and sea

Dwarfs (dvergar) are the smiths and craftsmen of the old stories, and they live in the earth and rock. The Völuspá gives them the longest list of names in the Poetic Edda but almost no description. After the gods shape the world, the dwarfs come to life in the earth, like maggots that grow in flesh, according to Snorri's Prose Edda. In the Völuspá they are shaped from Ymir's bones and from the blood of the sea-giant Brimir, and the gods give them mind and shape.

The long list holds names like Northri and Southri, Austri and Vestri, Gandalf and Thorin. Many of the names point to stone, staff, or advice. Think of dwarfs first as powers of the earth, and only second as people. They avoid daylight and work metal. Later books make them short, comic miners with axes, and that picture is modern. The Poetic Edda shows skill, advice, and cost, and no comedy.

Four of their names match the four directions: Northri, Southri, Austri, and Vestri. Stand in your home and face each direction in turn. Name the wall or corner that faces each one. Knowing a place well helps you move through it with care.

Where this comes from: The dwarf origins and name lists are in the Völuspá and Snorri's Prose Edda, which is late.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which three dwarf-names will you learn first? Name them, name their corners, and give three dated lines.*

Treasures from the forge

The gods could not have their finest tools without dwarfs to make them, and every gift had a cost. In Snorri Sturluson's Skáldskaparmál (Skaldskaparmal), Loki cut the hair of Sif, Þórr's wife, for sport, and had to pay for it. He got new hair of gold from the dwarfs called the sons of Ívaldi (Ivaldi), who also made Skíðblaðnir, a ship that folds up, and Gungnir, a spear that never misses. Then Loki bet his head against the dwarfs Brokkr and Sindri that they could not do better. They made Draupnir, a gold ring that drips more gold, Gullinbursti, a golden boar, and Mjölnir, a hammer with a short handle.

Loki's head was on the line, and only his wordplay saved him. The hammer's handle is short because Loki, as a fly, stung the smith's brow while he worked. The cost matters more than the shine. Every treasure costs something, good work costs effort, and careless tricks with other people's goods bring trouble.

Sif's gold hair shows the pattern: a careless wrong is repaired by fine work, and the repair is paid for. Use that lesson in your own life. Fine work deserves to be honored, not just owned.

Where this comes from: The Ívaldi and Brokkr treasures are in Skáldskaparmál, a late prose work.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which fine-made thing of yours needs mending? Name it, name its maker, and log the price and date in four lines.*

Völundr (Volund) the smith

Völundr (Volund) is the greatest of the elven-smiths, a master of metal who ends up crippled and captive. The Völundarkviða (Volundarkvida) tells his story. King Níðuðr (Nidud) hamstrung him, cutting the tendons in his legs so he could not walk well, and made him forge on the king's island. Völundr killed the king's sons in revenge for what was done to him and made cups from their skulls. Then he flew away on wings of his own making, and the king was left grieving.

Völundr is a warning, not a patron. The poem does not make him gentle. The tale is in the Poetic Edda, and it reads as stark and early. Honoring Völundr with a hammer and forge is a modern craft practice, honest only when called so. The lesson is plain: skilled people who serve a household should not be held against their will.

Pay the people who make things for you fairly, and thank them by name. Work freely given and fairly paid is the everyday opposite of Völundr's chains.

Where this comes from: Völundr's story is in the Völundarkviða in the Poetic Edda. Smith-patron rites are modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Whose skilled work do you rely on without thanks? Name that person, what you owe, and one way you will thank them. Give three dated lines.*

Alvíss (Alvis): all-wise till dawn

Alvíss (Alvis) is a dwarf who stayed talking until dawn, and that was his undoing. In the Alvíssmál (Alvissmal), Alvíss comes to claim Þórr's daughter as his bride, saying she was promised to him. Þórr does not refuse him outright. He asks the dwarf riddles about what each world calls earth, sky, and ale, and he keeps him talking until sunrise.

The poem ends with the sun in the hall. In a later telling, daylight turns dwarfs to stone, and that is how Alvíss ends. Þórr wins with talk and delay, and no magic. The lesson still applies. Answer a hard bargain with questions, not force. Sleep on a deal, and it may look different in daylight.

You can use the same tactic on a hard bargain: wait for daylight, and make the other side answer your questions in writing.

Where this comes from: The Alvíssmál is a poem in the Poetic Edda. Daylight turning dwarfs to stone is a later telling.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What pressure wants you to sign now? Name it, write its three questions, and sleep before signing. Give dated lines tonight.*

Stone: iron and honest work

Dwarfs are pictured as makers, not as distant blessers. They make things, finish them, and hand them over at a fair price. Rings are weighed true, blades hold their edge, and doors shut square. Smithies stood apart from the halls because of the fire. A marked tool outlived its maker by generations. The old north valued kept edges over fine words.

Here is the practice in plain terms. It is rebuilt from that pattern and is simple enough to keep. Keep a toolbox in order and one edge sharp. Commission one repair fairly, and speak one maker's name with thanks. The forge treasures are in Skáldskaparmál, and the toolbox habit is a modern household craft built on them.

A sharp knife comes from steady honing, not from talk about it. This week, spend one hour on a tool or a fix, and let your hands learn the job, one step at a time.

Where this comes from: The forge treasures are in Skáldskaparmál. The toolbox practice was rebuilt for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which tool, hinge, or hem is yours to fix this week? Name it, name the time you will give it, and log tool, work, and thanks in three dated lines.*

Norse Wheel of the Year

Winter Nights to Midsummer

An honest wheel

The old northern year was measured by work. In autumn, hay was stacked, cattle came in from the pasture, meat was salted for winter, and boats were hauled up onto land. In spring, lambs were born and seed went into the ground. Five seasonal turnings survive by name: Winter Nights, Yule, Dísablót (Disablot), Sigrblót (Sigrblot), and Midsummer. They come to us through Icelandic sagas, Snorri Sturluson's Heimskringla, Christian calendars, and folk memory. The sources are thin in places, and customs varied from district to district.

This book stays close to northern sources. You may know the eight-spoke wheel, which spaces the solstices and equinoxes evenly. It was put together in the last century from several cultures, so it is a modern tool and not an old northern one. This book uses the five northern turnings instead, and it marks thin evidence as thin. Midsummer is a later folk custom. The book watches the moon for pleasure and does not force a pattern onto it.

A year like this is learned by doing. One marked date teaches more than any diagram, and one small task you finish is worth more than a shelf of plans. Start with one date. Write it down in ink, and the rest of the year will have a fixed point to measure by.

Where this comes from: The five turnings are named in Icelandic sagas, Snorri's Heimskringla, and folk custom, but the sources are thin. The eight-spoke wheel is a modern invention.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Find which of the five turnings comes next. Mark its date in ink and read its pages once, with a warm drink in hand. Choose one small task to finish before the week ends and write it beside the date. Give it three dated lines.*

How each turning works here

Most turnings follow the same pattern. First comes the story, as the Poetic Edda and Icelandic sagas tell it. Next comes the old practice, as far as it can be recovered. Then comes a modern practice sized for a flat and one evening, then something for the table, and last ruled pages for your own writing. Dísablót has only one page, because the sources say almost nothing about it.

Old winters ran on food, fire, and company. In these pages you will meet the Yule peace, toasts to the ancestors, cleaned thresholds, and hill walks. Some of it is old, some is custom that lasted into recent times, and some was written for this book. Each page says which.

Your household already knows how to feast. Birthday bread comes to the table on its own plate. One soup fixes everything. One pudding is always asked for. This chapter adds five old names to the dishes you already love. Say an old name over a dish you already cook, and the meal becomes a marker of the season.

Where this comes from: How this chapter works. Its method is modern, built on old sources.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Sit down for twenty minutes and list the dishes that already mean joy at your table. Copy that list onto the reflection pages when you reach them. Give it three dated lines.*

The Rök stone sidebar

A tall grey stone stands in Östergötland, in Sweden. It is covered edge to edge with runes. It is the Rök stone, raised in the 800s. It holds the longest runic text from the Viking Age known to us. Its lines use alliteration, the repeated starting sounds of poetry, and tell of heroes, battles, a wolf, and robbery. The stone was carved with great care. Weather has worn it, but its writing can still be read.

The stone is a memorial and nothing more. Scholars still disagree about many of its lines. Nothing on it lists a festival or a calendar date, so it cannot prove any of the turnings here. Later calendar sticks, carved wooden sticks that counted feasts and moons, are a separate source. Their marks differ from valley to valley. The turnings do not depend on the stone.

The old calendar sticks share one habit worth borrowing. They keep count over time. The moon still waxes and wanes over your street. Looking at the sky twice a month builds steady attention. Short notes kept over time are more useful than arguments about the past. Step outside, look up, and write down what you see.

Where this comes from: The Rök stone dates to the 800s, and calendar sticks come later. No one knows whether the stone had any festival use.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Step outside tonight and find the moon. Note whether it waxes or wanes and write one line about the sky over your street. Keep those notes across the two months of the tracker. Give it four dated lines.

Moon tracker, two months: watch the sky, don't rebuild old rites. Note new and full moon dates.

- ☐ Month one, new moon — date + sky
- ☐ Month one, full moon — date + sky
- ☐ Month one — what changed around you?
- ☐ Month two, new moon — date + sky
- ☐ Month two, full moon — date + sky
- ☐ Month two — what changed around you?
- ☐ Which turning falls inside these two moons?
- ☐ One line: what did the moon teach?

Vetrnætr (Vetrnaetr): kin and burial mounds

Winter Nights (Vetrnætr) is the autumn feast that opens the winter half of the year, in mid-October. The harvest is in, the herds are housed, and the autumn slaughter is done. Icelandic sagas and calendars name it. Families gathered to honor their kin and the land spirits, and to thank the dísir (disir), female guardian spirits linked to households. A blót, a gift to gods and spirits often shared as a meal, was held, and toasts, drinks raised to a name or a wish, were drunk. Some sagas show toasts to Njörðr and Freyr for peace and plenty. Burial mounds were visited as the leaves turned.

The feast had two jobs at once. The living kin were fed first. Then the dead of the burial mounds and the dísir were thanked. The threshold was swept clean, and the main work of the day was to bring everyone, living and dead, under one roof.

Late autumn asks you to notice, not to plan. A fallen leaf, a shorter evening, and a project slowing for winter each deserve one true sentence. Write down what you saw. Over time, those notes become a record of the season.

Where this comes from: The Winter Nights blot is in Icelandic sagas and calendars, but thinly. The details come from later folk custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Take one short walk this week and look for signs of autumn ending. Find a fallen leaf, a shorter evening, and one project settling down, and write one sentence about each. Make no plan. Only notice. Give it three dated lines.*

Vetrnætr: old practice, modern rite

This autumn practice rests on thin early ground, so treat it as a careful guess. Icelandic sagas describe blot feasts and toasts, and little more. So this practice is openly a reconstruction, meaning a modern guess at the old shape. It needs one clean space, where every water jug and bowl is emptied and refilled, and one clear intent for winter. Small, careful work done on purpose is the whole practice.

A simple door wisp is twisted from straw or reeds. It is a modern craft for this book, not an ancient object, and it should not be passed off as one. Hang it on the door you use most, straight above the lintel (the beam over the door), as a sign of welcome to neighbors and kin. Keep it simple.

One space cleaned all the way beats three half-done ones. Finish it before you stop. Use hot water, a cloth, and a trash bag at your elbow. Write your intent for winter, a plain wish for the season, and set it above the cleaned space. Keep that wish in mind through the dark months.

Where this comes from: The blot feasts are thinly recorded. The space-cleaning was rebuilt for this book.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Choose one cleaning job for tonight and name it plainly: junk drawer, windowsill, or messy shelf. Give it thirty minutes with hot water and a cloth, and finish it completely. Write your winter intent on a slip of paper and set it above the cleaned space. Give it three dated lines.

Vetrnætr: table and kin

The feast uses food stored for winter. Salt pork comes with mashed root vegetables. Morning porridge comes with butter. Dark bread comes with thick slices of cheese. Ale or a fruit cordial is raised in toasts. Old feasts used the food from the slaughter season. Eat in the warmest room you have. Light a few candles against the October dark.

When the meal ends, the toasts begin. A toast is a drink raised to a name or a wish. Keep all the toasts to ten minutes. Raise three toasts aloud in plain words. Toast the kin present, then thank the dísir and landvættir (land spirits). Toast a winter kept well. Finish each cup. The food is folk survival. The spoken toasts keep an old custom alive today.

Three short sentences, kept for a season, teach more about family than a long list of resolutions. Keep each toast plain enough for a child to understand. Speak it standing, with your feet on the floor. Then keep saying it through the winter. Plain thanks spoken aloud link the living and the dead in your family's memory.

Where this comes from: Slaughter-season foods and toasts come from later folk custom, with hints in the sagas.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Rough your three toasts out on the reflection pages first, where crossings out cost nothing. Trim until a child could understand, then speak them standing at the table with feet on the floor. Toast the kin present, then thank the dísir and landvættir. Give it three dated lines.*

Reflection: which kin — living or dead — will you toast, and with what thanks?

Yule: midwinter peace

Yule is the old northern midwinter feast, held in the longest dark of the year, and doors were often barred early. It was a time of oaths sworn over a boar or a ring, which bound people to a promise. It brought toasts to gods and ancestors, and a peace over households, so that even enemies could eat without feud. Some Poetic Edda poems and Icelandic sagas tell of vows made at Yule being kept later in battle. Slaughter was done and stores were full.

Folk custom keeps the same shape in plainer clothes. Straw, a candle, and a cleaned house mark the season. The home grows quiet as the old names are spoken. You do not need a crowd or costumes.

Use the turning week for a small review of your year, like checking a ledger, a list of debts and payments. Sit still for one evening with a notebook. Name what finished, what you still owe, and what carries forward. Close one account, such as a debt repaid or a letter sent. Speak the names of the dead over supper, one sentence each. Repeat this check each year to give the dark months a shape.

Where this comes from: Yule feasting and oaths are thinly recorded in the Poetic Edda and Icelandic sagas. The details come from later folk custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Sit still for one evening and lay out your ledger. Note what finished, what you owe, and what carries forward, then close one account before dark. Speak the names of your dead over supper, one sentence each. Give it three dated lines.*

Yule: the quiet supper and the door

The old practice centered on feast and vow. People gathered and a peace was announced, and feuds paused under it. Oaths were drunk to gods and kin. The hall was crowded with meat stored for winter, and doors were barred early against the cold. Taking a vow in front of others was the core of the night.

This practice shrinks the hall to your own table. Make a plain supper from stored food: a pork or root stew, bread for dipping, skyr (a thick Icelandic dairy) with honey, apples and nuts. Set one extra plate for the dead, with the same portion as everyone else, and speak each ancestor's name and thank them. The Ancestors pages give a fuller script. The next morning, leave a share out for the birds.

After the meal, carry one lit candle from room to room, naming each person and sleeper under the roof as the light passes. Plan the route first so the walk takes under ten minutes, and keep your voice steady, not grand. Never leave a flame unattended. Naming people aloud is how a household says it is watching over them.

Where this comes from: Feast and vow-drinking are thinly recorded. Stored foods, the extra plate, and boundary walking come from later folk custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Hold this practice on one evening this week, in under an hour. Cook one simple dish and lay the extra plate, then eat slowly while you speak each honored name aloud with its thanks. Before sleep, walk one lit candle room to room and name each sleeper. Give it three dated lines.*

Reflection: what will you carry through the dark, and what stays buried here?

Reflection: what will you repeat every Yule, even in a tired year?

Dísablót: the ladies' feast

Dísablót is a late-winter feast that the Icelandic sagas name but never describe in detail. The name means an offering to the dísir (disir), female guardian spirits linked to kin, households, and fate. Some sources link Freyja to them, since she is also called Vanadís, lady of the Vanir. Only the name survives in the sagas. A later Swedish market, Disting, is sometimes linked to this feast, and the Idisi in the Merseburg charms were women called on to help warriors.

The sources are thin, and this page says so. No prayer, altar plan, or menu survives, and the Disting fair is a late link, not proof. This book builds one honest practice, clearly modern: a late winter supper that honors the women whose work shaped your household, living and dead, by name and aloud. Naming them gives them a place at the table.

Once a year is enough. Cook one dish from stored food, and name each woman in one true sentence while you eat. The fuller supper plan is on the Ancestors pages. Naming women who are often forgotten keeps their memory alive in your family.

Where this comes from: The dísir and the dísablót are named in the Icelandic sagas, but thinly. Disting is a later market. The supper was written for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Hold your supper on one February evening, in under an hour. Cook one dish from stored food and speak each woman's name with one true sentence. Log the names and sentences beside your ancestor cards. Give it three dated lines.*

Sigrblót: turn to summer

Sigrblót (Sigrblot) means "victory sacrifice," an offering made at the start of summer for success. The kings' sagas, such as Ynglinga saga in Snorri's Heimskringla, name it as a spring offering. It was made to ask for fair winds and success in war and at sea, and toasts were drunk before ships set out. Picture tar on rope at the shore, gulls over the crews, and a sail filling in an April wind.

Crews mended their gear before they sailed. Your household can keep the same shape. Name each member, each animal, and each sleeper, and bless them out loud. The name Sigrblót is recorded only thinly, and your blessing is a modern household custom.

In summer, dress your home in green. Dress a doorway with whatever green the week offers, and let it show that the people inside are named and honored. Green over the lintel and names said aloud mark the start of the season.

Where this comes from: Sigrblót is named in the kings' sagas, such as Ynglinga saga, but thinly. The household details were rebuilt for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Walk your thresholds this week and choose one to dress, such as a front door, a garden gate, or a doorway in your life. Use whatever green you already have, from your garden or a shop, and tie it over the lintel with string. Then stand under it and speak the names of everyone inside your circle of care. Give it three dated lines.*

Sigrblót: old practice, modern rite

Long ago, the practice centered on launching ships and making vows. Crews gathered and sails were blessed. Oaths were spoken before witnesses. Your modern practice keeps the gathering, the part where a crew is counted before it sails. One candle is carried around the home. It moves sunwise, meaning clockwise, where rooms allow. Name every member, animal, and sleeper in your circle of care (everyone you look after) at each door.

Then comes the greening, the happy part of the day. One doorway is dressed with green. Make a crown from what you already have, such as shop-bought flowers or greens. Keep any flame small and in a safe holder. Stand in a circle, and keep hands and clothes well away from the candle. Never light a bonfire indoors. Never carry flame near curtains. Never leave a flame unwatched.

The old launching served the crew. Your practice serves the household first. A written list read aloud is better than trusting memory. Say each member, animal, and sleeper inside your circle of care, once each. A steady candle and an honest list give the summer a shape you can keep.

Where this comes from: Launching and vowing are thinly recorded. The candle walk is a modern, safe version.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Write your list of names before you light the candle. Include everyone inside your circle of care this summer. Carry the list as you walk round your home, and read each name aloud at its door. Keep the walk clockwise and under an hour. Give it three dated lines.

Sigrblót: table and pledge

The table holds the first fresh foods of the year, which feel like a sharp break from winter. Green salads come with fresh cheese. Oatcakes come with honey. Home-brewed ale is poured where custom allows. Grill something outdoors if you have the space. People in flats can skip the grill and share warm bread. Set the meal near safe light, such as lamps or a few candles well away from curtains. The meal may run later than usual.

A pledge is a promise made out loud. You can make it alone or with dozens of people. Name one voyage you will launch this summer, such as a project, a trip, or a change. Say its course, its crew, and the harbor you are heading for. Drink the cup in front of witnesses, however few. Shared greens and shared meals are folk survival. Speak it plainly and keep your word.

This practice works best when you plan first. Saying a plan aloud to others makes it harder to forget. Prepare for your voyage, then keep your word, even when it is hard. Take one step you have planned, and your summer begins.

Where this comes from: Spring greens and shared eating come from later folk custom.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Write down one voyage you will launch this summer before the meal begins. Name its course, its crew, and where it should end on the reflection page. Then stand and drink to it in front of witnesses, however few. Give it three dated lines.

Midsummer: light that does not leave

Midsummer is a summer gathering around a bonfire and fresh green branches, and people in the north still remember it. It comes with flower crowns and hill fires. Many northern farms kept some part of it. Folk collectors such as Tillhagen recorded Midsummer greens and the custom of picking herbs at noon, and fires lit against a night that barely gets dark. Crowns wilted by midnight.

Joy taken with care is the mark of this day. People climb hills, enjoy the greenery only where that is allowed, and leave no trace. Food from many hands is shared. Name the grower, the carrier, and the cook. A flower means more when you name the people who brought it. Named thanks last longer than the feast.

Share one joy with one witness before the week ends. That is Midsummer kept small. A swim, a song, or a nap in full daylight will do. Choose one joy and tell someone about it. When you name the people who helped you find that joy, the light of the season stays with you longer.

Where this comes from: Midsummer greens and fires come from later folk custom. No old poem is claimed for them.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name one joy you will mark at this height of summer, such as a swim, a song, or a nap in full daylight. Show it to one witness, and write how you will share it before the week ends. Give it three dated lines.*

Midsummer: old practice, modern rite

As folk collectors recorded it, the old practice meant a fire and green plants. People walked uphill in crowds. Crowns were twisted at noon. Herbs were picked and hung up to dry. The summer light was praised where everyone could see it. Your modern practice keeps both at a size your week can hold. The hill can be a park slope, or a flight of stairs you count honestly. Your legs will feel the climb.

Taste one summer food on purpose. It may be grown at home, bought, or given by a neighbor with plenty. Then give thanks out loud. Speak one promise of care to someone who can hear it. Keep the promise short and specific. Say it slowly, then say it again so it sticks. Name the food and the person who shared it, so your thanks has a clear face.

In the old custom, greens and thanks belonged together. Climb a hill, speak a promise, and keep both in mind. Pick one clear step to take after the walk, and write it down.

Where this comes from: Hill fires and crowns come from later folk custom. The home version was written for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Plan your walk tonight so it fits inside an hour. Pick the hill, or the stairs, and write three simple rules: what counts as the climb, how you mark it, and when it ends. Walk it this week and log it honestly. Give it three dated lines.*

Midsummer: table and ledger

The feast opens with new potatoes and butter. Early harvest deserves the place of honor. Berries come with early apples. Fish comes however you like it. Honey sweetens the table. Whatever neighbors have shared from their plenty joins the spread. Each dish can tell its story of where it came from. That is its provenance (its origin). Say who grew it and what weather raised it.

The meal ends with the thanks ledger opened. A ledger is a plain list of what you received, kept here in a notebook. Write down everyone between soil and plate: growers, carriers, and cooks. Then set aside some of this week's extra food to give away. This tasting with its story is a reconstruction based on folk accounts. Read the story aloud. It links the person who eats with the person who grew the food.

Summer feels most whole when it is shared. Extra food set aside for others completes the thanks begun on the hill. A tasting with its story told aloud links the one who eats with the one who fed them. Keep your ledger of thanks, and carry a jar of extra food to a neighbor.

Where this comes from: The summer tasting was rebuilt from folk accounts.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

List three people who fed you this year. Match each one with a thanks you can deliver: a posted note, a jar carried round, or a small gift. Read your ledger aloud before you give. Give it three dated lines.

Reflection: what will you repeat every Midsummer, even in a tired year?

Plants & Trees

Herbs and ash

Safety box — read first

Some plants in this chapter can harm you. Read this page first and take it seriously. Yew is toxic in every part. Juniper oil and berries are not for swallowing. Wormwood and henbane relatives are toxic too. Never swallow anything from these pages just because a book says so. Do not identify wild plants without an expert beside you. Use store-bought teas only. Check every herb against your medicines with a clinician first. If you are or may be pregnant, check with a clinician before using any herb.

Your rule for this chapter is simple. Hanging herbs, keeping notes, and smelling plants are safe. Brewing is limited to store-bought tea, used with care. Meet yew, juniper, and wormwood with your eyes and notebook only. Never leave a flame unattended, whether it is a smoke bundle or a candle. Never drink wild water on walks. Leave no trace outdoors. Carry out everything you carry in.

Keep to eyes and notebook. Keep an expert beside you for any wild plant. Careful watching and a written rule help you learn without harm.

Where this comes from: Toxicity and caution come from classical and modern medical knowledge.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Write your own safety line here, dated. Name what you will never swallow and who your expert will be. Give it one firm line.*

Mugwort for the traveler

Mugwort grows along roadsides and on waste ground. It is a bitter, grey-green herb with pale leaf undersides. It is common, and it spreads easily. Northern folk custom linked it with travelers. It was tucked into shoes to ease weariness, and hung over doors at Midsummer. People also placed dried mugwort in dream pillows, in the belief that it brought vivid dreams. You can spot it at the roadside by the bus stop.

The pillow custom does not involve swallowing anything. Put a spoonful of dried, store-bought herb in a small cloth bag, and slip it under your pillow for one week. Three cautions apply. If you are pregnant, keep clear of it. Keep expectations modest: vivid dreams are a hope, not a promise. If you take medicines, check with a clinician first.

Keep your bedtime steady for the week. On the last morning, write one honest line about how you slept. Notice what helped you sleep and what did not, then write it plainly. Keep it short, small, and honest.

Where this comes from: The traveler and dream lore come from later folk custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Put a spoonful of dried, store-bought herb into a small cloth bag and slip it under your pillow for a week. Keep bedtime steady for the week. On the last morning, write one dated line about how you slept. Keep clear in pregnancy.*

Yarrow in old custom: look, don't use

Yarrow is easy to recognize once you learn its signs. Its leaves are feathery, like green lace. Its flat white flower heads stand along hedges all summer. Old books call it soldier's woundwort. Folk custom in many countries linked it with stopping bleeding (staunching). Some people used it for small cuts in the past. Today this book asks you only to look at it. Any old footpath in July passes a dozen clumps.

Treat this plant with care, and do not use it. Yarrow can cause skin irritation in some people. If your skin reacts easily, wear gloves when you touch it. This book does not ask you to apply it, eat it, or brew it. Never use it in place of prescribed medicine. Never use it for deep or doubtful wounds. Safety comes first.

Counting ten clumps teaches you the plant better than any book can. Sketch one leaf, and you will remember its shape more clearly than from a pressed specimen. Note the damp and trodden ground where it grows. A plant you have counted and drawn stays familiar when you need to recognize it.

Where this comes from: Yarrow's use for wounds appears in classical and folk sources.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *On your next walk, count every yarrow clump you pass and note where the ground is damp or trodden. Sketch one leaf in five plain lines. Count ten clumps. Do not gather anything. Give it three dated lines.*

Juniper: clean smoke — no ingest

Juniper stays blue-green through snow. Its berries are dusted with a pale bloom. Its smoke is sharp and clean. Northern farms burned juniper sprigs to cleanse the house and the byre, the cattle shed, before feasts. Some laid boughs on the floor to freshen the air. Folk collectors recorded cleansing with juniper smoke at Yule and at the spring turn, a custom of cleansing a place of harm. The smoke often hung low in the doorway at dusk. Burning it still fills a room with that smell.

Smoke is the only use here. Berries stay out of the kitchen. Juniper berries and juniper oil are harsh on the kidneys when taken in quantity. Never swallow them. This book never asks you to brew or swallow them. Its only use is cleansing smoke. Burn a bought bundle in a fire-safe dish, with a window cracked. Never leave it unattended. Keep the burning dish away from curtains and bedding.

Keep the smoke near the doorway, as old households did. Burn a small bought bundle while you watch it, or skip the smoke. Keep a window cracked while you burn it. Open a window, shake out the bedding, and air the room. Clean smoke and fresh air make the house ready for a feast.

Where this comes from: Juniper cleansing comes from northern folk custom. The rule against swallowing it is modern medical advice.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Air one room this week the old way. Open the window, shake the bedding, and sweep under the bed, then note the date aired and the weather. If you burn a bought bundle, burn it small and watched in a fire-safe dish. Give it three dated lines.*

Birch leaves: first green

Birch leafs out first, in a fresh, bright green. Its white bark peels in thin scrolls. Northern custom ties birch twigs into bundles called switches or whisks, used in the sauna. Folk tea used young leaves, and today you would buy them dried in packets. That tea is mild and fresh, like spring. Look up at the full leaves above you. Stand close and smell the damp, fresh air.

Being named in folk custom is an honor, not a prescription. Your own use stays small, bought, and written down. Bought dried leaf only, and one cup at a time, logged with date and amount. Never use it in place of anything a doctor prescribed. Check with a clinician first if you take regular medicines or could be pregnant.

A mild spring cup, taken with care and a written note, honors the first green. Watching two birches each month makes a calendar of the seasons where you live. Each visit teaches you what to expect next time. Watch the first leaves each year, and you will learn when to look again.

Where this comes from: Birch spring custom and leaf tea come from folk custom.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Choose two birches near your walk. Visit them monthly, from first leaf to last gold. Write one line each visit with date, stage, and weather. Write the clinician caution twice beside your log. Give it monthly dated lines.

Pine: tar and light

Pine was one of the most useful trees in the north. Its wood gave ship timbers and masts, and its resin was boiled into tar for sealing boats and rope. Resin-rich pine wood, called torchwood, was split for light. Knotty roots were split for kindling, and that kindling carried light through the Yule dark. In a pine stand at noon, the scent is thick. Light falls in shafts between trunks.

Pine is handled today as a source of light and warmth, mostly in small amounts you buy. Thank the wood as you use it, for its resin and its kindling. Buy firewood or kindling honestly instead of cutting trees yourself. Write the date you bought or used it in the same notebook. Dry kindling you buy is more useful than big plans about forests. Use only what you have bought or been given.

A tree you visit each year becomes a fixed point, something steady to measure the seasons by. Dry kindling you buy can light your midwinter nights. Visit one pine, note its date and how it stands, and it becomes a steady marker for your year.

Where this comes from: Pine tar and torchwood appear in sagas and folk life.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Find your nearest pine this week. Record where it grows and how it stands with date, then return at midwinter dark and add one line about light. Give it three dated lines.*

Nettle: respect the sting

You probably know nettle by its sting. It stings bare hands, so always wear gloves near it. In the past, young spring tops went into soups, dried leaves made a tea, and stems were twisted into cord. Few plants teach a simpler lesson. The plant that stings careless hands is useful to careful ones. A patch by the fence is often the first green of spring. The sting teaches you to wear gloves.

Gloves come before any use of this plant. Do not pick nettle for soup unless an expert has confirmed the plant with you in person. A book's description is never enough to identify a plant. Without that, use store-bought dried leaf for tea, and log each cup with date and amount. If you are stung, wash the area with cold water and watch it closely.

The order matters: gloves first, then any use. One cup of bought tea, tasted slowly, teaches the whole lesson. Log the taste in your notes, and stop there. Gloved hands that respect the sting can enjoy the spring tea safely.

Where this comes from: Nettle as food and fiber appears in old sources and folk life.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Brew one cup of bought nettle leaf tea this spring and drink it slowly, noticing its earthy green taste. Log it with date and amount, and write which gloves you will wear if you ever handle nettle with an expert. Give it three dated lines.

Elderflower cordial season

Elderflower arrives all at once in early summer. Hedges look foamed with white blossom. Folk custom turned the flowers into a sweet cordial, a drink made with sugar and water. The elder tree is treated as a lady to be asked before cutting. Thanks are spoken before any bloom is taken. Enjoy the scent from where you stand, and leave the blossom on the tree. Notice how the white heads look against the green hedge.

The berries come later, and the rules here are strict. Do not eat raw berries or green parts of the plant. This book does not ask you to pick elder. Use store-bought elderflower cordial or syrup instead, and follow the label. If you take medicines or are pregnant, check with a clinician first. Label every jar with the date you opened it.

A tree greeted properly is said to give twice: June flowers and autumn berries. Watching the tree through both seasons is the practice. Labeled jars of bought cordial carry the season into winter. Speaking thanks before taking anything is a habit that keeps the whole season sweet.

Where this comes from: Elder cordial and asking before cutting come from folk custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Choose two elders near your walk. Visit them monthly, from first bloom to last berry. Write one line each visit with date, stage, and weather. Do not pick anything. Give it monthly dated lines.*

Plantain of the wayside

Plantain grows flat where feet go. Its ribbed leaves press close to the path. Its flower spikes rise like thin green candles. Folk custom gave it names like waybread and wound leaf. Old custom sometimes used the leaf on sores and blisters. This book does not. In hard years, its seeds were saved and added to porridge. It stays low, gets stepped on, and still grows back.

This book does not ask you to use plantain on your body or in food. The old uses are history, not instructions. If you ever want to use a plantain product, buy it, follow the label, and check with a clinician first. Never use it in place of prescribed care, and never use it on deep or dirty wounds. Read this rule again if you are unsure.

A plant you describe in your own sentences stays in memory longer than one you only read about. Spend ten minutes with the ribbed leaves and spikes. Study the leaves where they grow, and you will recognize this plant wherever you walk.

Where this comes from: Plantain's wayside uses come from folk custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Find a plantain on a path and study its ribbed leaves and spikes for ten minutes. Sketch it in five lines, and write the clinician caution twice beside your log. Do not pick or use any part of it. Give it three dated lines.*

Meadowsweet: mead-wort

Meadowsweet grows in damp meadows and sweetens the air in high summer. Its creamy flower heads nod over ditches. You often smell almond before you see it. Folk custom kept it to flavor mead, a honey drink, and summer cordials. The Swedish name mjodort means mead wort, which fits its use in mead. On a hot day, a full stand hums with insects. Its scent and its use were linked.

Old books name this plant, but a name is not permission to use it. Your use stays small, bought, and written down. Bought dried flowers only, and one cup at a time, logged with date and amount. Never use it in place of doctor's orders. It contains salicylates, a family of compounds that aspirin is related to. Anyone on medicines should check with a clinician first. Tell your doctor if you use it.

A single cup, tasted slowly and logged honestly, is the monthly practice. Notice the almond, the hay, or the river in its scent before the cup cools. Give the plant fifteen minutes of full attention.

Where this comes from: The name mead-wort and its tea use come from old sources and folk custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Check with a clinician first if you take medicines or are pregnant. Then brew one cup of bought meadowsweet tea on some unhurried afternoon, and give it fifteen minutes of full attention. Note what the scent reminds you of and write three lines before the cup cools, logged with date and amount. Give it three dated lines.*

First meetings: where does your chosen ally grow, and when will you visit it across the seasons?

Ash: the world tree

In Grímnismál (Grimnir's sayings), the ash tree Yggdrasill holds up the nine worlds. You can see why when you stand beneath a large one. Its bark is grey and ridged. Its buds are black. Its winged seeds hang in bunches. Its timber is springy and strong, so it was used for spears and tool handles. In the Poetic Edda, Yggdrasill is an ash, and its roots reach to wells where the Nornir (the Norns, who shape fate) sit. Put your palm on the bark. It feels cool and straight.

This tree grows straight. Year after year it adds steady wood, the kind once used for spears and shafts. Think of it as a picture of patient, steady work. Its straight trunk shows steady growth over many years.

Visit one ash in each of the four seasons, and it becomes a familiar friend. Watch the buds open and the birds change above the bark. Tell it one short piece of news, and notice what has changed when you return. Walking with one tree through the year gives you a steady place to measure your own growth.

Where this comes from: The ash as world-tree is in the Poetic Edda, and ash timber was widely used.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Choose one long project in your life, such as a skill, a repair, or a savings goal. Visit an ash tree this week for twenty minutes, and write where it stands as your first entry. Then log it across all four seasons. Give it four dated lines.*

Birch: bright beginner

Birch leads the spring, with white bark and bright green leaves. It is among the first trees to leaf and among the first to turn gold. Northern farms used its bark for containers and roofing. Poets often mention birch beside pools. Coppice workers (people who cut young shoots for reuse) cut birch rods for baskets. One small tree serves many uses. Peel only bark that has already fallen. Never cut a ring around a living trunk, which can kill the tree.

Learning comes lightly, in small steps, and it takes time. A single sentence heard in passing can change how you see a problem. It rarely arrives all at once. One reading, one walk, and one conversation a week keep it growing.

Small gains add up over time. A shared meal, something you make, or a good talk can help. Name the person who helped, and you will remember the lesson longer. Watch for these gains for one month.

Where this comes from: Birch use appears in sagas and folk life.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Carry one question for a full month. Each week, do one reading, take one walk, and have one conversation about it. At the end, name one new insight, where it came from, and who helped you see it. Give it four dated lines.

Rowan at the threshold

Rowan trees grow near doorways across northern countries. People planted it beside houses and holy wells. Old custom trusted it on doorways, gateposts, and cradles, believing it guarded against harm. It is a small tree with a light crown. Its berries stand scarlet against grey stone. People valued it as a guard more than as timber. Look for rowans near doors as you walk. Stop and look at the berries when you pass one.

You can care for a rowan in plain ways. Your part is to notice it often. Take only fallen wood, and never cut a branch without permission. You can write a blessing, put it in a small bag with a fallen twig, and hang it by the door.

A threshold you name and tend feels different from one you only lock. Put a hand on the frame, take one breath, and say one kind sentence as you cross, each day for a week. Watching over a doorway keeps your home in mind.

Where this comes from: Rowan at the threshold is a folk custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name one threshold in your life that needs more care tonight, such as a front door, a bedroom door, your inbox, or your temper. For one week, greet it with a hand on the frame and one kind sentence. Then write what changed. Give it three dated lines.*

Yew of the dead — no ingest

Yew can outlive the trees around it. It stands dark green against grey stone through every month. Its wood was prized for bows in many lands. Modern plant science confirms that every part of yew is poisonous. Take no teas, no berries, and no experiments. Keep the old lore on the page, and keep it out of your cup, your pot, and your hands. Look, remember, and touch nothing.

Remembrance, not use, is the meaning of this tree. Yews often grow in churchyards and gardens, where they give shade. Sit beside one and think of whoever comes to mind. Take nothing away except notes. Take no clippings, no berries, and no bark. The ash page is about steady patience. The yew is about remembering the dead, Its danger is why you only sit beside it.

Being present here asks for no ritual and no request. Keep your phone in your pocket and a notebook open. Let names come to you without chasing them. Quiet minutes under dark green branches are a way of honoring the dead.

Where this comes from: Yew's link to the dead is an old association, and its poison is a plain fact. The rule against swallowing it is modern medical advice.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Sit ten quiet minutes beside a yew this week, and do not touch it. Keep your phone away and a notebook open. Let names come to mind, then write down who came in one honest line. Give it one dated line.*

Oak: the slow king

Oak measures time in centuries. You feel it when you stand under one. Its timber built ships and door posts in the north. Oaks can stand for hundreds of years, even with hollow trunks. In old stories, the oak is a central, steady tree. Put your palm on the bark. It feels ridged, cold, and steady. A lone oak in a field often stands for generations. Stand close and feel its size.

The oak takes its time. Season after season it adds slow, strong wood. An old oak can keep standing with a hollow trunk. This tree teaches you to think in seasons, not days.

Watching an oak through the seasons keeps you steady. Guess its girth (width around the trunk), note the birds, and tell it a short piece of news, year after year. One oak followed through all four seasons gives your year a steady point to return to.

Where this comes from: Oak timber and long life appear in sagas and folk life.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Choose one oak near you and walk to it this week, taking about twenty minutes. Note where it stands and how it looks today, including its lean, its branches, and the light. Then log it across all four seasons. Give it four dated lines.*

Plant ally log: name your ally from these pages, then log its leaf, flower, seed, and date at each turning.

Seasonal gathering calendar: what will you gather, where, and in which month? Ask-first rule noted.

Liminal Places

Wells that remember

Wells and the gifts left in them

Bog water and spring water have kept things for a very long time. Long ago, people laid swords, cauldrons, and brooches in lakes, bogs, and springs. Diggers still find them where rivers slow and springs rise. Scholars call these gifts votive deposits. That means objects given on purpose to a place. The custom did not fully die out. At holy wells in the northern and western lands, people still walk a circle (called a round) around the water and tie cloth to a tree or post above it. Some old gifts went in whole and some did not. What mattered most was the giving itself.

A well is a place with its own history. It is not a machine that grants wishes. Old deposits are well documented: they were found, lifted from the ground, and recorded. Rounds and cloth trees are living folk customs, kept by families who look after each site. Tossing coins into a living spring is a newer habit of visitors, and coins can pollute the water. Never drink wild water, because you cannot know what is in it.

When you visit, walk the round as it is kept at each place. Where no round is marked, walk once around sunwise, meaning clockwise in the northern half of the world. Tie only cloth that will rot away, such as natural cotton or wool. Ask leave before you lift any water, and sit a while to listen before you leave. Where the well is built over, stand at the nearest marked spot instead. The visit takes under an hour. Take nothing away from the site, and leave only what you chose to give. Keep any promise you made to the place.

Where this comes from: Old gifts in lakes and springs are found by archaeology. Rounds and cloth trees are living folk custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name your nearest spring or well. Give the day you will go, the round you will walk, and what you will leave there. Write it in three dated lines.*

Sea roads

For the Old Norse, the sea was a road. In Icelandic sagas, it links farms that could never meet by land. Voyages often begin with vows and end with thanks, and some sagas mention gifts to the sea and wind. A shore belongs to neither farm, and open water is where hard bargains and farewells are made. Promises made on a crossing are held to account: people check whether they were kept.

No shore owns the middle of the water, so every promise made there must be said out loud and kept. Crews name what they leave and what they carry, and they speak their terms while still on the water. To reach the far bank, say your terms plainly and keep them.

Many people now live with an unfinished move, a half-paid house, or a task that was never finished. The old idea of a crossing still helps. Every crossing has a bank behind you and a bank ahead. On each crossing, choose one thing to carry over and one thing to set down. Write the marker on a slip of paper, and say the words aloud. Nothing needs to be burned or buried. The crossing is finished when you keep the terms you set.

Where this comes from: Sea-voyage vows appear in Icelandic sagas as a story pattern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name the crossing you are in now. Name the bank behind you and the bank ahead. Write what you will carry over and what you will set down. Give it three dated lines.*

The doorway at home

Every doorway is an edge between outside and inside, and folk custom treats it that way. People have put juniper sprigs above the lintel, the beam over the door, and a pinch of salt along the sill. A verse is said when going out, and a breath is taken when coming home. You touch the door frame many times a day without noticing. This habit asks you to notice it once. These are folk habits from many households, not one single ritual.

Spend four minutes at the door you use most, once a month or at each turning of the seasons. Sweep the sill down to the bare step. Put fresh salt where the step meets the street. Hang a store-bought juniper sprig above the lintel, or store-bought rosemary if juniper is not on hand. Take a breath inside, then say one verse as you step out. Use store-bought herbs only, and do not eat or drink them.

When you come home, pause in the doorway for one breath and say one thank-you. Missing a month undoes nothing. Start again with the sweep, salt, green, and verse. Nothing is burned or buried, and the broom does much of the work before any words are spoken. A door kept this way helps the people inside feel settled.

Where this comes from: The threshold habits come from folk custom in many districts. The monthly schedule was written for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Choose the doorway you use most. Clean it and add a green sprig. Write your going-out verse and your coming-home thanks. Give it four dated lines with today's date.*

Dawn, dusk, and Yule night

Twice a day, the light is neither fully day nor fully night. Once a year, at Yule (midwinter), the season does something similar. In Icelandic folk belief, the mounds stood open on Yule night and the dead could walk near the living. Dawn and dusk carry a smaller daily version of that opening. The house is quiet, the edges show clearly, and birds wake or settle as the light shifts. Even a city window shows the change.

In old stories, edges were meeting times. People meet at the shore, where land meets water. Bargains were made and messages passed, and dreams carried warnings that guided voyages and killings. Dream warnings are a story device in the sagas, not proof that anyone kept dream books, and this book does not decode dreams. The phrase "thin places" for such spots is modern. Showing up on time at the edge was the offering.

Try three dawns or three dusks in a row. Sit at a window or on a step for ten minutes. Do not rush. Notice the light and count three sounds. If cloud hides the sun, keep the same hour anyway. By the third day, the change in light should be easier to notice.

Some old northern and Old English texts blame certain sicknesses on outside beings, such as elves (álfar) and the mara, a night-presser who sits on sleepers. This book takes only the habit of watching the edges. It does not diagnose or treat illness. If you are unwell, see a clinician.

Where this comes from: Meetings at edges and dream warnings appear in Icelandic sagas as story patterns. The phrase "thin places" is modern.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Choose dawn or dusk. Keep it three days in a row for ten minutes at the same window or step. Write light and three sounds after each sit. Give it three dated lines.

Well visit: go, tidy, listen. Write the date, place, what you tidied, what you heard, and what you left.

Sea-road worksheet: what you are crossing, what you carry over, what you set down mid-water.

Three-day sit log: dawn or dusk, for three days. Write the light, the sounds, and what changed. Date each day.

Runes

Stones with staves

Runes cut on stone

Run your finger along a stone's cuts in low light and you feel the shape before you read it. A rune is a letter of the old runic alphabet. The Elder row, the older set in order, has twenty-four runes. They are cut on spearheads, on gold bracteates (thin gold medallions), and on standing stones, from roughly the second to the eighth century. The row begins fehu-uruz-þurisaz-ansuz-raidō-kenaz. Those six runes give the row its name, futhark, which is taken from its first six letters. The Kylver stone on Gotland carries the whole Elder row in order. Centuries later, the Younger row uses sixteen signs, in short-twig and long-branch forms. It was cut from roughly the ninth to the twelfth century on stones such as Rök and Jelling.

The two rows differ in length, not in purpose. The Elder row spells things out fully. Its twenty-four runes are grouped into three families of eight. Later books call them the kin of Freyr, Hagall, and Týr. The Younger row shortens the writing to sixteen signs and leaves more to the reader. Stones give family names and memories. They say a stone was raised for a father. They never give spells or fortunes. The medieval rune poems (Norwegian, Icelandic, and Anglo-Saxon) pair each rune with a short saying. Wealth must move. Ice gives no grip. A torch shows the way. Read each saying slowly, one at a time.

Your hands can learn the runes before your mind does. The first cuts were made by hands holding chisels, and hands still learn them best. Draw straight lines with a ruler, say each name aloud, and count the branches on each rune. Using your hand and your voice together helps the shapes stick. If the whole row feels like too much, start with the first six runes.

Where this comes from: The rows are cut on stones from the 2nd to the 12th century, and the rune poems give the verses. The study practice is modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Copy the Elder row one evening and the Younger row the next, using a ruler for straight lines. Sound each name and count three branches. Write which row your hand prefers and where the runes match. Give it four dated lines.*

Seven runes for your journal

This book uses seven short runes. Each rune has a saying that the medieval rune poems give. Fehu is cattle and wealth, which must move to stay alive. Uruz is the strong aurochs, a wild ox, pulling through mud. Þurisaz (Thurisaz) is the thorn that guards by pricking whoever grips it. Ansuz is the mouth of Óðinn, speaking counsel. Raidō (Raidho) is the road and riding, which can be smooth or hard on the feet. Kenaz is the torch that shows the evening work. Hagalaz is the hail that breaks roofs and bows to no one. Say each name aloud. Each rune fits a small slip of paper with its name on one side and its saying on the other.

These rune names and sayings come from the medieval rune poems. The Norwegian, Icelandic, and Anglo-Saxon rune poems each speak in their own voice. Everything else in this practice is modern, and this book says so. The book does not claim that Viking Age people cast runes like this. The set is narrowed to seven because it suits a journal rather than a temple. The three-rune spread is modern. It sets out root, trunk, and branch from left to right.

Ask one true question and boil it down to a single line. Lay three slips from left to right for root, trunk, and branch. The root shows what the matter rests on. The trunk shows what is steady. The branch shows what may grow. Ten minutes with pen and slips is enough. Write the date at the top of the page. Keep every cast in the same notebook pages across the months. Casts can show patterns that one night cannot.

Where this comes from: The seven meanings are from the medieval rune poems (Norwegian, Icelandic, Anglo-Saxon). The narrowed set and the three-rune spread were written for this book.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Boil one true question to a single line tonight. Draw three runes for root, trunk, and branch. Date the cast and write three plain sentences. Keep every cast in the same pages.

Staves

use them honestly

Galdrastaves are late; use them honestly

Galdrastaves are late. They are not Viking Age runes. A galdrastave is a magic sign drawn in a charm book (a book of spells and charms). The earliest bound staves in Iceland appear in AM 434 a 12mo, an Icelandic charm book of the late 1400s. They were drawn beside remedies. The books many people know are early modern. Galdrabók (Galdrabok) dates to the 17th century. Lbs 4375 8vo dates to the 1860s. They mix a Christian frame, with Latin, runes, and pictures together. Ægishjálmr (Aegishjalmr), Helm of Awe, has old poetry behind it. Vegvísir (Vegvisir), the way-pointer, dates to the 1860s. It appears in the Huld manuscript, a 19th-century Icelandic collection. It is not a Viking Age sign.

They stand as early modern folk practice, not Iron Age practice. In books such as Galdrabók, their power comes from calling on Christ, Mary, and angels alongside older names. They were drawn on paper or wood and carried. Calling them Viking amulets (lucky charms worn on the body) is a modern label. Kept in their own period, they stay accurate.

Draw one stave on paper this week. Choose Ægishjálmr or a stave from AM 434 a 12mo, and write the date, book, and purpose beside it. Carry the paper for a day. Then bury it in soil or recycle it, with thanks. Use paper only, not skin, in this book.

Where this comes from: The staves come from AM 434 a, Galdrabók (17th century), and the Huld manuscript (1860s), all late. This book leaves out any Viking Age use.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Copy one stave on paper this week. Note the date, the book, and the purpose. Carry it for a day, then bury it in soil or recycle it. Log what held in three dated lines.*

Draw your valknútr (a sign of three linked triangles): trace the threes that matter to you, such as breath, blood, bone, or your own.

Valknútr (Valknut) is old; the rest is newer

The valknútr (knot of the slain) is three triangles locked together. It is cut on Viking Age picture stones beside riders and ships. Its link to Óðinn is only suggested, by the scenes it appears in, not by a written label. Many people today read it as a sign of threes that matter, such as breath, blood, and bone, or three of your own choosing. Some carved stones are worn but plain, and their shapes can be hard to read. Trace the turn with your hand first. Your hand learns it faster than your eyes.

The other marks belong to other places and times. The triquetra (a knot of three pointed loops) belongs to Early Christian and medieval art. Most tangled knotwork sold as a Viking badge is either medieval or modern craft. Enjoy them as craft. Called Viking, they mislead. Of the signs in this chapter, only the valknútr is Viking Age. The rest is newer. Loving them as craft takes nothing away.

Sketch a valknútr on paper first, showing three triangles interlaced. Note the date each time. Next, draw it in chalk on your own step, and score (cut shallow lines in) a loaf of bread before baking. Each takes under half an hour. Note where each mark went and what washed away. Practice a little at a time until your wrist knows the turn.

Where this comes from: The valknútr is cut on Viking Age picture stones. The triquetra comes from Christian and medieval art.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Describe your valknútr in words, then draw it. Note which way its points turn and where it went. Give paper, chalk, and bread dates in three dated lines.*

Draw and mark tracker: where did your valknútr go this month?

- ☐ Paper copy — date
- ☐ Doorway chalk — date
- ☐ Bread scored — date
- ☐ Stitched or drawn on cloth — date
- ☐ Garden or path marking — date
- ☐ Gift given with the mark — date
- ☐ What held, what washed away?

Galdr: Charms

Words in old books

Galdr: the sung charm

A charm is a short set of words said or sung for a purpose. A galdr is a charm that is sung or spoken aloud, not one thought in silence. In the Hávamál, Óðinn lists the songs he knows, the way a carpenter lists tools, and each one has its work named: one blunts an enemy's blade, another loosens chains from the wrists, and so on. The Sigrdrífumál shows the same pattern in a smaller way, when Brynhildr teaches Sigurðr rune songs for sword, ale, and healing.

The voice is the teaching. No tune survives in the Poetic Edda. The Hávamál gives purposes and boasts, never notes on a staff, and the medieval rune poems give names and meanings, never a music book. Any modern galdr with set tunes, robes, and staged circle work is a modern rebuilding, and it is honest when called so. What the sources show is plainer: a verse learned by heart, said aloud, and said with care.

Keep it simple. Learn one verse by heart and speak it aloud in a low voice at the same window three mornings in a row, without strain. A sung charm here means practiced words that calm your nerves, not weather you command.

Where this comes from: The charm list is in the Hávamál and the rune counsel is in the Sigrdrífumál, both in the Poetic Edda. No tunes survive, so any modern tune is rebuilt.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Name the verse you will learn by heart. Speak it at the same window three mornings. Write the date, the verse, and what steadied you. Give it three dated lines.

Words in old books

Old northern voices survive in plain lines inside physician's handbooks and the Old English leechbooks (old medical handbooks). The Merseburg-type charms from mainland Europe are close cousins in language. They speak healing over bone and blood. They say joint to joint, blood to blood.

Surviving northern words lean toward protection and sometimes healing. This chapter follows only the protective side. Four workings are here, and each one protects or blesses. To ward means to guard. There is a walk around the room, a knot for the road, a bundle for the door, and a blessing of water. Nothing here curses or binds another person. Keep any words short enough to remember.

Cangemi's PhD thesis (Luthien Cangemi, UCL, 2024) gathers the spoken healing charms into four shapes that return in the Old English leechbooks and the Merseburg-type charms. One is a blessing spoken over the sick. One is a firm command that tells illness to leave. One is a holy story told as an example. One is a prayer said alongside the words. Any speaking in this book stays rebuilt household protection only. It is never a cure or a prescription. If you are ill, see a clinician.

Where this comes from: The Merseburg-type charms and the Old English leechbooks are old written sources.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name one part of your life that needs guarding this week. Write it in one line with no defeating and no fixing. Pin it where you work. Give it three dated lines.*

Circling and cleansing

Walking a ring around a person or place, with your feet and your voice, is an old form of protection. The walk is called circling. The turn runs sunwise, meaning clockwise in the northern world, across northern custom. You walk around the person or place with a blessing until the circle closes. Beside it stands the body cleansing (a blessing with juniper or water). It cleanses the body part by part, as if dressing for the day. End with thanks to close the ring. Carl-Herman Tillhagen, a Swedish folk-custom collector, recorded Swedish farm protection customs as folk practice, so it is a sound source.

Both shapes come down through a few old written hints and everyday folk practice. They appear across prayers and custom and were not invented here. The meaning for a home is simple. The ring says this ground is watched. The cleansing says this body is dressed for the day. A hallway, a garden bed, and a bedside all suit the ring. Your own words work well before sleep. Having someone walk the ring with you makes it more meaningful.

Walk one small circle around a single room. Say a short line of protection and close with thanks at the door. Keep it under twenty minutes. For the cleansing, say six short lines, one for each part from head to foot, and touch each part as you say it. If you use juniper, use store-bought sprigs only, and do not eat or steep them. Repeat it often, and the habit will feel easier.

Where this comes from: Circling and cleansing come from folk custom. Tillhagen recorded Swedish farm customs.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Walk one circling tonight around a single room. Speak plain protection and close with thanks. Write your six-line cleansing from head to foot. Log where you walked in three dated lines.*

First working: the knot charm

You need a length of wool or linen cord. Folk custom across many districts ties protection into knots. Tie three knots slowly. Say one short blessing line over each knot as you pull it snug. The first knot is for the body, the second for the home, and the third for the road. Say each line aloud on your out-breath as you tighten the knot. Three knots and three lines make one charm.

Knot-tying for protection is folk survival. It comes from many households, not one ritual. This renewal habit is modern practice built on that custom. A charm that is never checked can fade, so the practice includes renewal. At each turning of the season, untie the knots and tie them fresh, saying the lines anew. Retying is part of the care. Write a date on a tag or in the margin, so you know when the next turn is due.

Make each line short enough to say in one breath. Tie the cord at a table. Then hang it high, near a draughty window or door, where daily brushing will not wear it thin. The work takes about twenty minutes with hands and voice. When the cord frays, wash it and tie it again. If the cord feels damp, let it dry before you hang it. Check the knots each time you walk past, and retie any that have come loose.

Where this comes from: Knot-tying for protection comes from folk custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Draft three short knot lines, each brief enough for one breath. Tie your cord tonight and hang it. Write lines, place, and date. Give it three dated lines.*

Second working: the doorway bundle

A small bundle above the lintel holds household names. Tie a store-bought juniper twig and a store-bought rowan twig together with string. Rest a pinch of salt in a scrap of cloth. Write the names of the people under the roof on paper. Hang the bundle above the lintel of the door you use most, where you will see it each day. Keep the binding plain and the knot firm. Skip decoration. A thimbleful of salt is plenty. It is a token, not a supply.

Juniper at the threshold, salt at the sill, and green over the door appear in folk custom. They come from many households, not one old recipe. Seasonal renewal is a modern habit with an older feel. At each turn of the season, fresh salt and fresh green go back in, with names spoken aloud as you set them back. Clearing out the old with care matters as much as hanging the new. Each name you put back inside keeps its place.

The bundle takes half an hour with string and shop supplies. At renewal, pour old salt onto bare soil away from plants and paths. Never throw it in the bin beside the door. Put old green into soil or running water with thanks. Never bin it. Clear the old bundle with thanks before you make a new one.

Where this comes from: The doorway ingredients come from folk custom.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Make your bundle in half an hour. List contents and names in your journal tonight. Renew with fresh salt and green at the turning. Write all in three dated lines.

Third working: the water blessing

Clean water in a small bottle brings a little of the well indoors. Draw it from your own tap with thanks, or from a well where you asked leave and took only a little. Keep it sealed apart for blessings, and label it not for drinking. Flick drops sunwise around a room, across the threshold, or onto your brow. This follows an old pattern called aspersion, which means sprinkling. It is a small household copy of well custom. Keep the bottle high and away from drinking vessels and small hands.

This working is reconstructed from well custom, not copied from one ritual. It keeps the habits of asking leave, taking little, and turning sunwise. The rule is to use little. Never drink from wild water. Never fill a bottle from a protected spring. Never take more than the blessing needs. Change the water each month. Pour the old water onto plant roots, so nothing is wasted or harmed. Little and often is the whole method. Drops, not drinks.

Keep the bottle near a spot you use every day, such as your desk or your bedroom door. Opening, flicking, thanking, and closing takes minutes. If you are unsure where to start, use the door you use most, since it needs the most care. A little water given often keeps the house feeling cared for.

Where this comes from: The water blessing was rebuilt from well custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Choose where your bottle will live and what it blesses first. Bless once and log date and place. Renew when the month turns. Give it three dated lines.*

Uncrossing and repair

Charms can wear out, tangle, or get dirty. That is a sign they need care, not a sign of failure. Folk custom expects renewal, the way a house expects dusting. Uncrossing means taking the working apart gently. Knots are untied and cords washed. Bundles are emptied and sills swept. Water is poured out and bottles scrubbed. Name what slipped without shame and without hurry. Work in daylight with the windows open. Taking things apart feels like tidying, because it is.

The remade working should be one step steadier than before. Keep the new parts simple, so they are easy to check next time. Give the new working a week before you change it again. Use a stronger line on the knot, a neater round at the door, and walk the circle once a week for a while instead of monthly. The renewal pattern is reconstructed from custom. The repair shape is modern and called so. Mending matters more than a perfect first try.

Pick one charm that feels worn. Spend twenty minutes to uncross, clean, and remake it. Write down what slipped and what steadies it. Do this in a calm moment, not in a rush. Close with thanks. Notice how the house feels the next morning and write it down. Write the date beside the new work, so you can see how long it lasts.

Where this comes from: The renewal pattern was rebuilt from custom. The repair steps were written for this book.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Find one working that needs it tonight. Uncross, clean, remake in twenty minutes. Write what slipped in one line and what steadies it in the next. Give it three dated lines.

Charm log: write which working you made, the date, and who it was for. Record all three.

Home ward tracker, week one: walk the circling and mark each day.

☐ Day 1 — walked?

☐ Day 2 — walked?

☐ Day 3 — walked?

☐ Day 4 — walked?

☐ Day 5 — walked?

☐ Day 6 — walked?

☐ Day 7 — walked + knots checked?

☐ What held this week?

Home ward tracker, week two: walk the circling and mark each day.

☐ Day 8 — walked?

☐ Day 9 — walked?

☐ Day 10 — walked?

☐ Day 11 — walked?

☐ Day 12 — walked?

☐ Day 13 — walked?

☐ Day 14 — walked + bundle checked?

☐ What held across both weeks?

Ancestors

Mound-neighbors

Mound-neighbors

Low green mounds in the fields are old burial places. Haugr, the burial mound, stands in Icelandic sagas as the home of the dead. In those sagas the dead keep watch over cattle and weather. People greeted them with toasts poured at the door-stone and kept their paths swept. Egils saga (Egil's Saga) and other Icelandic sagas show gifts laid and words spoken at mounds. This book does not try to wake them. In this telling, your people are not far off. They are neighbors near dusk, close enough to be remembered at the table.

This closeness is gentle. It is for comfort, not proof. Mounds and ship-settings (stone outlines shaped like ships) are found by archaeologists, the people who dig up and study past sites. You can visit them. The talking dead come from Icelandic sagas. That is a story pattern, not a map. Nothing here asks you to prove or perform anything. One shared meal a year is enough. A card, a letter, or a list of names also works. These are small ways to remember. Grief is welcome here, and so are good manners.

A name can be honored with no ritual at all. Light a candle, speak a name, and remember one true thing. That is all it takes. Set the candle on a steady, flat surface, away from curtains and paper. Never leave a flame unattended. Put the candle out before bed. Fuller remembrance is on the supper page when you are ready. There is no test. Speak a name and be kind.

Where this comes from: Mounds appear in Icelandic sagas and in archaeology.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Rest with one name tonight. Light a candle if you like, speak the name aloud, and never leave it burning unattended. Write one true sentence before sleep. Give it three dated lines and the time you put the candle out.*

The quiet supper script

This supper sets one more plate than the living need. The first half of the meal is eaten in silence. Serve a simple, hot meal. Soup, bread, or a dish they used to make can be the food. Light a candle for each name you will speak. Keep an empty chair for them. Eat together in quiet, and the dead share the hour with you.

Halfway through, speak each name aloud with one true sentence. Offer a thanks, a memory, or something you never said. Then eat the second half while keeping them in mind. The shape comes down through folk custom. Many households kept it. This script is one gentle modern version. It is meant for Yule or Winter Nights. Once a year is plenty. Steady remembrance matters more than grandeur. Tears are fine.

After the meal, close with thanks and put out the candles. Never leave a candle burning when you leave the room. Leave a little food out for birds or neighbors in the morning. The whole practice fits in an hour, not counting the dishes. Leave the names by the bed until morning.

Where this comes from: The quiet supper comes from folk custom, with hints in Icelandic sagas.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Choose the menu and names tonight. Keep the supper inside an hour at Yule or Winter Nights. Write the menu, names, and morning notes. Give it three dated lines.*

Ancestor card, first: write the name, dates, one story, one thing they left you, and one question.

Ancestor card, second: write the name, dates, one story, one thing they left you, and one question.

Grief letter and roll call: write a letter you will not send, then list the names you will speak at Yule.

Oath

Go on reading

Your vow page: fill it in. I will keep ___ for 30 days. I will not ___. Witnessed by ___.

Books behind this book

Primary sources, in translation

The Poetic Edda — trans. Carolyne Larrington, or trans. Jackson Crawford (Hackett, 2015).

Snorri Sturluson, The Prose Edda — trans. Anthony Faulkes.

Völsunga Saga (The Saga of the Völsungs) — trans. Jesse Byock; trans. Jackson Crawford.

Egils saga — in translation.

The rune poems: Norwegian, Icelandic, Anglo-Saxon — in translation.

Witnesses, histories, law

Tacitus, Germania.

Ibn Fadlan, account of the Rus burial on the Volga.

Adam of Bremen, Gesta Hammaburgensis Ecclesiae Pontificum.

Landnámabók.

Grágás (the Grey Goose Laws).

Sigvatr Þórðarson, Austrfararvísur.

Ynglinga Saga.

The Merseburg Charms.

Old English leechbooks.

Scholarship and teaching

Jackson Crawford — YouTube channel: Norse mythology, language, sagas, and culture.

Luthien Cangemi — The Art of Healing in Medieval Iceland, PhD thesis, UCL, 2024.

Carl-Herman Tillhagen — Swedish folk custom records.

Go on reading

Four old texts go further into this subject. Read small parts in public translations before you buy anything. The Poetic Edda in Larrington's translation opens with the seeress and the counsel of Hávamál. Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda in Faulkes's version tells the stories plainly. The Völsunga Saga in Byock's translation follows Sigurðr to the pyre. Egils saga tells of a poem that buys back Egil's own head in York. Borrow them first, so you can judge them fairly.

Read these books first as stories, and second as lessons. They are original old texts, in translation, not summaries. They reward slow reading. For each part, ask what happened, what it means at home, and what small act answers it. Let the answer settle over a week. A chapter a week is a good pace. Keep a notebook beside you, and write your answers there.

Start with one book and one starting day. The next morning, sit in the same spot and read the next section. An hour or less per sitting is plenty. Pick a time that suits you and keep it. When you finish, pass the book on, and mark the page that held you longest. Keeping to your reading plan is a small vow you can keep.

Where this comes from: The primary texts to read next. Go meet them.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Commit to one book and one starting day. Begin the next morning in the same spot. Write book, day, and the page that holds you longest. Give it three dated lines.